

111. **Cast one's bread upon the waters** = to be kind always without expecting immediate reward, e.g. Few people have been known to be able to cast their bread upon the waters.
112. **Change of scene** = a removal from one place to another, e.g. Robbery in Lagos is now undergoing a change of scene.
113. **Chapter of accidents** – series of troubles e.g. As his animals died, one after the other, he experienced a chapter of accidents.
114. **Chasing the rainbow** = running after or pursuing something that could not be got e.g. Man's desire to swim like a fish is as realizable as chasing the rainbow.
115. **Chip off the old block** = like his father, e.g. Bayo is, in all respects, a chip off the old block.
116. **City fathers** = the town councilors e.g. There will be an election of city fathers in the middle of the week.
117. **Clean sheet** = with one's misdeeds cancelled, e.g. Having confessed his sins to the Reverend Father, Julius was asked to come to God on a clean sheet.
118. **Cleanse (or clean) the Augean stable** = to stop or eradicate corruption or immorality, e.g. Military governments usually pretend that they clean the Augean stable in some states.
119. **Clear the decks** – to remove impediments or obstacles, e.g. A candidate who reads hard is the one who clears the decks for his examination.
120. **Close finish** = an exiting and interesting race or contest e.g. Betting on horse is usually a close finish.
121. **Close on the heels of** – not far away from the object one pursues, e.g. The robbers did not get far because the police were always close on their heels.

EXTRA GRAMMATICAL ENTRIES (III)

PHRASAL VERBS

1. Akin was **bailed out** yesterday – **guaranteed freedom**.
2. Although there are problems Yinka says he will **bear up** – **be brave or courageous**.
3. The factory was **blown up** – **it exploded**.
4. The bicycle tyres need **blowing up** - **to be filled with air**.
5. When he saw his brother, the young boy **broke down** - **started crying**.
6. My car gives me a lot of trouble, it **breaks down** often – **go wrong and stop working**.
7. When he saw his brother, the younger boy **broke in** – **forced their way in to steal**.
8. The headmaster **broke off** his leave – **end something suddenly**.
9. Epidemic **broke out** last year - **started suddenly**.
10. The musicians will **break short** their concert this evening – **end it suddenly**.
11. "The school **breaks off** next week," he said – **finishes, goes on holidays**.
12. The headmaster **broke up** the fight - **stopped**.
13. "What **brought about** the quarrel?" he asked - **caused**.
14. She will **bring back** the ruler - **return**.
15. My old photographs usually **bring back** memories of my youth. – **make somebody remember**.
16. Government will **bring down** the prices of goods – **make lower or less**.

17. Reading the right books **brings on** success – makes something to happen.
18. Dr Williams **brought up** his children – looked after them and educated them.
19. He **brought up** his food – vomited.
20. The efficient doctor will **bring** the woman round – revive after having fainted.
21. No one should **burn down** government property – make something to burn until it falls down.
22. The candle has **burnt out** – burnt until nothing is left.
23. "Let's **burn up** your stew since we're travelling," Sade suggested – use everything.
24. The Pastor will **buzz off** if you insult him – go away.
25. I will **call at** Abeokuta, on my way to Lagos - stop.
26. The strike action will be **called off** tomorrow - stopped.
27. "I can't **call on** you next week," Ade said – make a brief visit to someone.
28. You cannot **call out** here – shout.
29. Azikiwe was **called up** in the 1920's – enrolled in the army.
30. It is good to **carry out** one's duties well – finish what has been planned.
31. The builders **cast aside** the block – threw it away because it is useless.
32. The boxer **cast off** his overall – to get rid of something.
33. There is food to eat and no one **caters for** it – provide for all one needs.
34. The police **checked up** on the suspects – found out whether something said/done is true.
35. The story Franca told me **cheered me up** – made happy.

36. The dust-bin was **cleared out** – made empty.
37. The sky soon **cleared up** towards the evening – became bright.
38. She is used to **clearing up** my kitchen – making it tidy.
39. The University was **closed up** for nine months - shut.
40. The restaurant **closed down** when the owner's father died – stopped trading.
41. Angry words and insult **colour up** Pa Gilbert easily – make him become red in the face or blush (angry).
42. How did the accident **come about**? - happen.
43. He **came across** some pencils – found without searching for it.
44. The radio set has now **come apart** – become broken.
45. He was **come back** to, when they discussed the riot of 1979 – remembered by some people.
46. She **came by** a pair of earrings - found.
47. They **come from** Ondo State – be from a place.
48. His travelling plans **came off well** – succeeded, worked out well.
49. The book will **come out** soon – be ready for sale.
50. The examination results have **come out** – become known.
51. The Professor **came out** with the information – told others what is unknown.
52. She did not **come round** yesterday – came back to life after she fainted.
53. The Accountant **cooked up** the books – gave false account /told lies about the account.
54. The fan has **cooled down** the room – made to become less hot.

55. She **cooled down** after the fight – **became calm**.
56. We can **cope with** the Mathematics lesson – **do something difficult**.
57. Friends do **correspond with** one another – **write letters to and receive**.
58. A British Prime Minister **corresponds to** an American President – **is the same as**.
59. He was **covered with** sadness – **full of**.
60. A rabbit is **covered with** fur - **has all over its body** .
61. The negligent doctor **covered up** his mistake at the theatre - **hide**.
62. Mary **covered the stew pot up** – **put a lid on the pot**.
63. His illness **cropped up** before the school re-opened – **happened suddenly**.
64. When he came from his farm he **curled up** – **to lie with one's arms and knees close to one's mouth**.
65. The lie he told made me **curl with** anger – **be full of feeling**.
66. The water supply was **cut off** recently - **stopped**.
67. The big town was **cut off** from the village – **completely separated from**.
68. He **cut off** the cake – **brought out part of it**.
69. Please **cut out** rudeness; the Pastor advised – **not to do something**.
70. Olu is **cut out** for music – **has talent to become a musician**.
71. The old woman was **cut up** by the incident – **very sad**.
72. It **dawned on** him that his wife would die – **become clear in one's mind**.
73. He **dipped into** his book – **read a part of something or spend a part of one's money**.
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74. It is bad to **do people down** – cheat people.
75. This cloth will **do for me** or – **be right for**.
76. Tola **did up** my room at Christmas – cleaned and fixed things up.
77. Some people can **do without** food – **be all right without**.
78. "I don't have enough money," Nkechi said, "but I'll make do **with** the little I have" – **manage/ be all right with**.
79. When he told his story every one **doubled up** with laughter – **bend one's body with laughter or pain**.
80. Your examinations are **drawing near** – coming close.
81. The louvre frame **fell in** at twilight – broke and dropped down.
82. She **fell in** with her mother's advice – agreed to.
83. His plans to marry a blonde **fell through** – failed.
84. The couple **fell out** with each other this morning – quarrelled.
85. He lives **far off** from me – a great distance.
86. My reason is **far from** what you think – not at all.
87. Fatimat said she was **fed up** with typing all day – angry/ tired of doing or facing something monotonous.
88. Wall Geckos **feed on** insects - eat.
89. **Fill in** your answers, the teacher told his students – **writé facts/ answer**.
90. The water has **filled out** the bucket – become more or bigger.
91. When mother met me on table, she told me to **finish off** – eat something until there is no more.
92. The racing car was **flagged down** – told to stop by making signals.

93. Our company may **fold up** soon – **come to an end/fail**.
94. Christianity **frowns on** immorality – **does not approve of**.
95. Ibitoye **gets along** with people easily – **makes friends**.
96. My uncle **gets at** his son to read – **say something to someone often or to shout at someone**.
97. The smart politician **got in** the cabinet – **was chosen for**.
98. They **got off** the programme last week - **started**.
99. Adam **got on** well with Eve until God sent them packing – **work or live in a friendly way**.
100. I will **get round** my sister who said I should not go to tonight's party – **make someone to do what he/she had refused to do**.
101. He did **get through** – **pass his examination**.
102. We **got through** one thousand dollars in America – **use up all – money/things**.
103. We shall **get together** and tell you what to do – **meet**.
104. I **got up** at 4'0'clock everyday – **wake/rise**.
105. They **gave off** some journalists – **set out**.
106. It will **give out** on Monday – **come to an end/be used up completely**.
107. Samuel **gave up** singing at school – **stopped trying**.
108. Stanley **gave over** smoking two years ago – **stopped doing something**.
109. When she did not arrive at the agreed time, I **gave up on** her – **thought she would not come again**.
110. After appealing to my father, he **gave way** over the issue – **agreed after he disagreed**.
111. Anger **gave way** to my silence – **took over from/ started in place of**.

112. We **made up** our differences – **settled/ended** our quarrel.
113. The house help **mopped up** the spilt milk – **cleaned**.
114. Only lazy people **nose about** for news – **look for**.
115. It is not polite to **nose into** your neighbour's affairs – try to **find out details of**.
116. The vulcaniser by the bend of the road has **packed-up – stopped working/stop doing something**.
117. The footballer **passed out** after his training - **fainted**.
118. The children **paid for** what their father did - **suffered**.
119. The children **pick at** food – **eat slowly with no interest**.
120. Sayo **picked on** me to clean up the toilet – **choose someone to do something unpleasant**.
121. I **picked up** Hausa when I went to Kano – **gain or acquire easily/by chance**.
122. If you look well you will **pick up** a nice dress at the market – **buy/ find**.
123. Adeolu **pitched in** because he needed popularity – **worked hard**.
124. Remi **pitched in** dying – **started to do it in a busy way**.
125. Segun **popped off** as he saw Angeline – **went away**. "Pop off" also means **to die**.
126. He **pressed for** promotion at work – **continually asked for**.
127. He **pressed on** with his work – **hurried up**.
128. They **pulled apart** the antelope – **tore it into pieces**.
129. The new Oba **pulled down** the old palace - **demolished**.
130. After nine months at the hospital, Akin finally **pulled through – survived (illness, trouble) etc**.
131. The car **pulled up** in front of the supermarket – **stopped**.

132. It is wise to **put some money by** every week – **to save something for the future.**
133. He **put** his School Certificate Examination **off** – **postponed** it
134. "**Put out** the fire," the old man cautioned – **make something to stop burning.**
135. It may not be easy to **put two people up** at a time – **give someone a bed at night.**
136. Christiana said she would not put up with the noise of the neighbour's children – **accept, bear.**
137. They **put up** at Hotel Diganga – **stayed (for a short time).**

PREPOSITION

A preposition is a word which shows the relationship between one person/place and another. You, look around you. Anything you find does not stand alone. You are likely to find a book, **on** the table; your shoes, **under** the locker and a boy, **in** the class.

So, now, you see that nothing exists alone. Therefore, **on, under, in**, are all prepositions. Other prepositions include the following:

about	down	unlike	unto
above	during	up	like
across	except	with	near
after	for	without	for
against	from	within	opposite
along	in	apart	through
amid	of	among	till
before	over	as at	towards
behind	on	at	until
below	per	by	concerning
beneath	regarding	but	considering
beside	round	under	undemeath
between	since	despite	beyond

It must be noted that prepositions are very delicate words which attract different verbs to themselves, meaning different things. Find listed in the table, some verbs and the prepositions that go with them.

Verb / Adjective / Noun	Preposition
Accustom (ed), conform, indifferent, look, oppos, according, related, similar, succeed, superior, senior, junior, write, reply, tie, bind, reply, agree	to
Accuse, afraid, ashamed, boast, careful, consist, cure, composed, deprive, die, full, guilty, independent, jealous, proud, repent, sure, suspect, tired, warn, victim, disapprove, confident.	of
Different, part, recoil, suffer, return	from
Charge, agree, angry, comply, confer, cover, fill, pleased, popular, satisfied, interfere, meddle, shake, abide, shiver, tremble, part, write	with
Exchange, live, Blame, die, live, feed, spend, sit, insist, come,	on
Aim, shoot, throw, point, angry, arrive, connive, disgusted, glad, good, bad, slow, quick, indignant, look, stare, spy, gaze, pleased, rejoice, sit, surprised.	at
Absorb, arrive, believe, confide(nce), die, disappointed, dressed, fail, good, interest, sit, succeed, write.	in
Abide, benefit, come, walk, take	by
Protect, kick, work, talk, speak	against
Wait	upon

MATTERS ARISING FROM PREPOSITIONS

You can **write** to a **person** but **write** something e.g. poem, note etc.

You can agree **to** a suggestion or something but agree **with** somebody.

You can **die of** a disease, illness or a condition of difficult e.g. he died of asthma.

One is **confident of** oneself or others but have **confidence in** oneself or others.

Popular with means **loved by** e.g. He is popular with girls. He is loved by girls. (It does not mean that he has popularity among them).

One can **write with** a writing material, e.g. pen, pencil.

One can **write in** ink, or paint.

One can **die for** a cause or what one believes in e.g. Stephen died **for Christ**.

One can **die on** a guillotine.

One can **live on**, that is, feed on food or exist on money or a means of livelihood, e.g. The old man lives on his monthly pension dues (he survives by spending his monthly pension dues).

Good at shows proficiency or expertise in something, e.g. He is **good at** games.

One can **abide by** a regulation = keep a law or regulations.

But one can **abide with** a person = live or stay with, e.g. If I go to London, I will abide with friends.

PREPOSITION RULES

1. POSITION

To show **position** of things, use: **beside** (not *besides*—***besides*** means ***also***, as in: He is dirty, ***besides***, he is lazy)—**on, to, between, in, outside, near, above, over, below, beneath, under, underneath, by, among.**

2. DIRECTION

To show **direction**, use: **up, down, along, round, out, into, across, toward(s), to, up to, away from, over, under, past, through, in front of, behind, between, on to, on, of, inside.**

3. TIME

To show **time**, use: **until, till, from, since, before, by, after, past, at, during, through (out).** When you mention a day, use **on** — **on Monday**; a month, or time of day, use '**in**' — **in November, in the morning, in the afternoon, in the night/ at night.**

4. PLACE

- (a) If a place is geographically obscure (not well known), **at** is used, but if it is a metropolis or a well known place, **in** is used e.g. He lives **at** Njenkwu but she lives **in** London. Also, when a small place is mentioned in relation to a bigger one, **at** is used for the smaller, **in** for the bigger. He lives **at** Mokola **in** Ibadan. (Mokola is a street within Ibadan City)
- (b) Although, **in** is used for well known places, it may be used if it is **not a final destination**, e.g. On my way to America, I stopped **at** (not: **in**) London and finally arrived **in** Canada the following day.

5. EXPRESSING TIME

At shows particular time: **on** shows specific, exact time, **by** shows loose time, **in** shows restriction as in:

- (a) Please see me **at** eight. (**particular time**)
- (b) The meeting starts **at** five, try to be there **on** time. (at exactly five)
- (c) You should have come **by** noon, latest.
- (d) The meeting starts **at** five; be here **in** time. (**before** or **latest**, **at** five)

6. AGENCY PREPOSITION

To show who did what, use **by**. The use of **by** here shows that what was done was intentionally done, e.g. The hen was killed **by** him (Ade). Here Ade is the agent, i.e. the person that brought about the death of the hen. To show that something was **not** done intentionally or that a non-human agent is responsible, use **through**. He died **through** an accident. The patient died **through** (not: **by**) the doctor's carelessness. (The doctor did not intentionally kill his patient). Use **with** if what has happened is the consequence of what is described, e.g. She was struck **with** cold. He was down **with** fever.

There is metaphoric or idiomatic use of preposition as in: **on** earth, **on** leave, as in: He is **on** leave. She is **on** the board of directors. Here, 'leave' and 'board' are not physical things. They are abstract.

7. TRANSPORTATION PREPOSITION

- By:** Come/travel/go/leave: **by** bus, train, water, road, air, foot
- Be:** **on** – a plane, bus, bicycle, motorcycle, ship
- Be:** **in/on** a bus
- Get:** **on** – a bicycle, plane
- Sit:** **in** the boat
- Take:** a train
- Be:** **on** board a plane (not: **in** a plane)

Model Question 1

His suggestion is completelythe point and cannot be accepted. (a) to (b) about (c) beside (d) on (e) under

Clue to answer. Use rule 1.

Model Question 2

My little boy is sufferingjaundice. (a) from (b) of (c) for (d) with (e) by

Clue to answer. See preposition table (check **from**).
Check questions 36, 41, 77, 86, 93 (1979).

Model Question 3

He told me to go ontill seven. (a) to work (b) worked (c) works (d) working (e) work

Clue to answer. After any preposition, the verb must be in ...ing.
Use rule 20.

Check question 89, 95 – 100.

Model Question 4

Government should prevent smugglers their contraband.
(a) to sell (b) to be selling (c) from selling (d) having sold (e) to selling

COMPARISON

When we discuss comparison, we discuss adjectives at their different levels of application.

Adjectives are words which describe mostly nouns and pronouns but sometime adverbs.

Adjective	Comparative	2nd Degree	Superlative
1. tall	taller	much taller	tallest
2. beautiful	more beautiful	much more beautiful	most beautiful

Now: Let me ask you: why do we have **taller** but not **beautifuller**? Some adjectives at the comparative and superlative levels take **er** and **est** while some take **more** and **most** as in 1 and 2 above respectively.

An adjective will take the **er** at the comparative, if it is monosyllabic, i.e. it is pronounced at **one** stretch e.g. **tall, short, big** etc or if it is bisyllabic, i.e. it is pronounced in two sound beats, e.g. **hand - some** (2 bits) **use - ful** = (2 bits). If the adjective is pronounced in more than two beats, that is, polysyllabic, it will attract **more** and **most** before it at the **comparative** and **superlative** levels respectively e.g. Beau-ti-ful (3 beats, i.e. trisyllabic) will have **more** beautiful, **most** beautiful.

Wonderful too will be: **more wonderful, most wonderful.**

Rules for comparison

1. Only monosyllabic adjectives take **er** and **est** at the **comparative** and **superlative** levels. (as discussed above)
2. You cannot use **more** + adjective and at the same use **er** e.g. **More taller**, but, simply, **taller**.

3. When only two things are compared, you cannot use a superlative adjective e.g. Olu and Ade are friends. Olu is the **tallest**. (superlative) (wrong). But: Olu is the **taller**.

However, if more than two things are being compared, you must use the superlative adjective. You will know that two things, people or places are being compared when you see: **the duo/duet, couple, twins**. More than two people, things or places are compared when you see **the lot, of all, the trio, the quartet, the triplets, the quadruplets** etc.

4. There are some irregular adjectives. Learn their forms so that you will know their comparative and superlative forms.

They include the following:

Adjective	Comparative	2nd Degree	Superlative
ill	worse	much worse	worst
bad	worse	much worse	worst
good	better	much better	best
many	more	much more	most
little	less	much less	least

5. Any time you find a **comparative** adjective, **than** must be in front of it. Or whenever you find **than**, you are expected to use a **comparative** adjective, e.g. He is **short** **than** Sade. (short is not comparative therefore it is wrong)

Right: He is **shorter** than Sade. (**shorter** is comparative)

6. You cannot use adverbs of degree, e.g. **very, so, or too** before any comparative adjectives, e.g. The boy is **so/very/too + taller** (wrong) (comparative adjective). Neither can you use **very** or **too** with a superlative adjective e.g. He is **too tallest**. But: He is **too/very/so + tall**.

7. Some adjectives of two syllables, e.g. handsome = hand-some (2 syllables) have two comparative & superlative forms. It can be **handsome/more handsome/ most handsome** or **handsome/handsomer/handsomest/**
8. It is possible to have: **Very many more** books are here than are there.
9. There are certain adjectives that cannot be compared, i.e. they cannot appear where **than** appears. They are called **ne-plus ultra** or **ceiling** or **unique** or **ultimate** adjectives. They include: **unique, superior, inferior, senior, junior, right, wrong, supreme, paramount**, all shapes including **triangular, circular, rectangular, correct, final** e.g. It is wrong to say: This is **more superior than** that. But say: This is **superior to** that.
10. Occasionally, **any** may come before a comparative adjective. See UME, 1985, question 88.
The boy thought that driving a car was not **any more** dangerous **than** riding a bicycle.
Also you can have: She is not **any older** than me. Here, **any** + comparative adjective is intended to lessen the effect of "She is **older** than me". She is not **any older** than me.
11. As answers to **as**, in comparison: This is **as** bad **as** that.

Model Question 1

The weather is probably appealing for people who live in Jos for foreigners. (a) as much / as (b) no less / than (c) more / as (d) at least / as

Clue to answer. Use rule 11.

PLACE ORDERING

When we have a set of adjectives or words, how do we arrange them?

The basic formula is the **DOENH** approach – and they should appear in the order in which they are listed.

- (D) stands for **Deictic**. In this group are all determiners. You know determiners such as **a, the, little, some, many, few, a little, much, this, that, several, a lot** etc. If there is any of them, it comes first.
- (O) stands for **Ordinalators**. (These include: ordinals and cardinals). Examples are one, first, two, second, ten, tenth, seven, seventh etc.
- (E) stands for **Epithets**. **Epithets** are adjectives. They are divided into two:
 - (a) **Subjective adjectives**: These are adjectives that do not have to do with **age, shape, colour, materials** etc. Instead, they show debatable quality – one person may say, she is beautiful, another may see her as ugly. So, adjectives that are open to controversy come under here, e.g. good, strong, presentable, durable, handsome etc.
 - (b) **Objective adjectives**: These are of definite classes and should be arranged in the following order (the quality being mentioned here is fixed): **SIZE, SHAPE, AGE, COLOUR, MATERIALS, PARTICIPLE** (e.g. racing, woven) formula = **SI-SH-A-CO-MA-PA** = **SI** for size, **SH** for shape, **A** for age, **CO** for colour, **MA** for materials and **PA** for participle.

(N) stands for **Nominal**. Nominal refers to the makers or origin of the item being described, e.g. American, Ibo, Okrika, Asian, French etc.

(H) stands for **Head**. What you are describing e.g. bag, chair, dress, car, etc. Please remember that the disarranged words must be re-arranged in the order **D** to **H**, taking great care under "EPITHET", using the **SISHACOMAPA** formula. Rearrange this:

Big these four new boxes rectangular wooden brown American well-decorated boxes = **These** (Deictic) **four** (Ordinator) **strong** (Subjective epithet) **big** (Size) **rectangular** (shape) **new** (age) **brown** (Colour) **wooden** (Material) **well-decorated** (Participle) **American** (nominal) **boxes** (Head).

= These four strong, big, rectangular, new, brown, wooden, well-decorated, American boxes.

Now see the past question references and try the answers.

Model Question 1

They went to the market and bought a suitcase and bag.
(a) a big leather (b) a leather brown big (c) a big brown leather
(d) a brown big

Clue to answer. Check under **Epithet (E)**.

Model Question 2

On his way back, the boy ran into a long procession of men, women and children in
(a) white beautiful exceedingly flowing gowns
(b) exceedingly flowing white beautiful gowns (c) white flowing exceedingly beautiful gowns (d) flowing exceedingly white beautiful gowns

Clue to answer. Check under **Epithet (E)**.

Model Question 3

The poor man was pleased to find tyre. (a) a rubber old discarded (b) an old discarded rubber (c) a discarded rubber old (d) an old rubber discarded

Clue to answer. Check how to rearrange adjectives from **D** to **H** in the table above.

Model Question 4

Mrs Ojo was one of in my village.

- (a) the first two enlightened young ladies
- (b) the two first enlightened young ladies
- (c) the two first young enlightened ladies
- (d) the first two young enlightened ladies

Clue to answer. Use the **DOENH** order.

Model Question 5

He put in a basket. (a) a white dozen eggs (b) dozen white eggs (c) a dozen white eggs (d) white dozen eggs

Clue to answer. Use the **DOENH**. Note that you cannot have "dozen eggs" but "a dozen eggs". However, note that you cannot put an **s** in front of dozen, in case you have more than one dozen ... to pluralise dozen, thus:

I need two dozens of egg. X

BUT

I need **two dozen** eggs.

Ten **dozen** chairs have been brought here.

Note, also, that after mentioning **dozen**, whether you have **one** or **ten** before the word **dozen**, the noun should be plural, e.g.

Not: One dozen **egg** but: One dozen **eggs**

Also relevant for note is that whenever you have a noun in front of **dozen**, no matter what happens, the **verb** must be plural, e.g. Two dozen oranges **are** here.

One dozen spoons **have** (not: **has**) been brought.

Note: **dozen** is an **irregular plural**. Others like it are: **hundred**, **thousand**, **million**, **head** and they obey the same rules.

Finally, this again is the pattern of arrangement of words disarranged:

D: a/an/the/some etc.

O: one/first/ten/tenth etc.

E:

- (a) **Size** – large, medium, etc.
- (b) **Shape** – triangular, spherical, cylindrical, circular, etc.
- (c) **Age** – old, new, model, ancient, stale, etc.
- (d) **Colour** – blue, red, etc.
- (e) **Materials** – metal, wooden, cement, iron, etc.
- (f) **Participle** - wanted, shining, spoken, etc.

N: Maker or Origin of the item (if included in the disarranged words)

H: The item we are describing.

So we can have this:

D:

O:

E:

(size)

(shape)

(age)

(colour)

The

tenth

largest

oval

antiquated

gray

(material)	-	plastic
(participle)	-	glittering
	-	Australian
N:	-	cup

H:
The tenth largest oval antiquated gray plastic glittering Australian cup.

Note: Most questions come form under the epithet, that is **Size, Shape Age Colour Material Participle (SI-SH-A-CO-MA-PA)** principle.

Re-arrange this:

We saw **two, the, American, drinking, small, new, circular, brown, mugs**

PLURAL COMPOUNDS

A compound word has more than one word constituting it, with a hyphen linking each word. As there are compound adjectives so are there compound nouns. Since adjectives – whether in simple, one-word form or the compound form – cannot be pluralised (e.g. beautiful – beautifuls), we will here deal only with plural forms of compound words which are pluralised.

Rules

1. When a preposition and a noun form a compound, the noun **NOT** the preposition will carry the pluralising 's' morpheme e.g. on-lookers**s**, by-standers**s**, in-comers**s**, out-goers**s** etc.
2. When two nouns are to form a compound, it is the last noun that carries **s**, e.g. tea + cup – teacup = teacups face – cloth – facecloth = facecloths**s**.
3. Occasionally, a noun may precede another noun but the **first noun** will perform an adjectival (describing) function for the second noun. In this case, it is the second real noun, not the first noun performing like an adjective and cannot carry the (**s**) (of course we have said that adjectives cannot carry (**s**) at the end). So, we have: **Boy + scout**, where boy is describing the type of scout, differentiating it from **girl**, or **man** or **woman** scout. **Boy** therefore is a **denominalised** adjective (functionally). So, we have Boy-scouts, not Boys-scouts.
4. When a title forms a compound, the adjective part of it will not carry the morpheme **s** e.g. Financial Secretary, Secretary-General, in both cases i.e. Financial-Secretaries, Secretaries-General. Also: Chief – of – Staff = Chiefs – of – Staff.

Note: Whenever a hyphen divides two, three or more words, if the noun is a person's title, start with a capital letter:

Chief-Justice not: Chief – justices

Auditors – General not: Auditor-generals

Here is a list of common compounds:

Parents-in-law, commanders-in-chief, auditors-general, accountants-general, heads-of-state, secretaries-general, justices-of-the-peace, on-lookers, by-standers, on-goings or goings-on, bye-laws, bye-elections, girl-guides, boy-scouts, boy-brigades, dining-halls, ante-rooms, call-girls, play-boys, deaf-mutes, bitter-sweets, fire-engines, post-offices, face-clothes, coffee-times, bread-crumbs, shirt-sleeves, dance-halls, factory-workers, adding-machines, walking-sticks, record-players, notaries-public, tissue-paper, remains tissue-paper.

Model Question 1

They spent the last holiday with their (a) sister-in-laws (b) sisters-in-law (c) sisters-in-laws (d) sisters-in-laws

Clue to answer: See the list of common compounds above.

Special note

There are some words closely related to plural compounds. They have to do with adjectives and nouns like **plural compounds** as a topic.

Here is a list of few:

- (a) **Student Affairs** (Section) not: Student's Affairs
- (b) **Woman Affairs** (Ministry) not: Women Affairs
- (c) **Parent – Teacher** (Association) not: Parents-Teachers

You will notice that, in a, b and c, **Student, Woman, and Parent-Teacher** are merely adjectives describing **Affairs** (a & b) and **Association**, which are nouns.

As already pointed out, adjectives do not take **s**, that is, you cannot pluralise an adjective. Or, can you say, two beautifuls girls?

Attempt this: Model Question 2

When I was in the secondary school, my parents were active members of the..... (a) **Parents-Teachers-Association**
(b) **Parents'-Teachers'-Association** (c) **Parent-Teacher-Association** (d) **Parent's-Teacher's-Association**

REPORTED SPEECH

To repeat a message already passed by someone else, there are two methods of doing it.

(a) Direct Speech Method

Characteristics

- (i) The **exact message** must be reproduced without omission or addition.
- (ii) **Inverted commas** are used to mark the exact message.
- (iii) The original speaker's identity + **said/asked/opined/** (choose whichever is applicable) must be written, e.g.
He **said**
She **asked**
They **opined** that

A general example of the direct speech is shown here:

A: **Original Speaker:** *I am in school now and I will come to school tomorrow.*

B: What did **A** (the original speaker) say?

C: He said, "***I am in school now and I will come to school tomorrow.***"

(Reporting directly, what **A**, original speaker said)

(b) Indirect Speech Method

- (i) The original message must change some of its parts.
- (ii) No inverted commas will be used because we are not reproducing the original message.
- (iii) The original speaker's identity + **said/asked/opined/** must be written.

Now, in b(i), it is noted that the message must change. The following are the things that will change:

AT THE SUBJECT LEVEL

- * **I** will change to **He / she**
- * **We** will change to **They**
- * **Our** will change to **Their**
- * **You/it** will not change
- * **This** will change to **That**
- * **These** will change to **Those**

AT THE PREDICATOR LEVEL

- * **Will** will change to **Would**
- * **May** will change to **Might**
- * **Can** will change to **Could**
- * **Must** will change to **Had to**
- * **Ought to** will change to **Had to**
- * **Need** will not change
- * **Dare** will change to **Dared**

All action (lexical) verbs must change to past, e.g.

- * **Go** will change to **Went**
 - * **Know** will change to **Knew**
 - * **Has** will change to **Had**
 - * **Is** will change to **Was**
- Note: **Come** will change to **Go**

AT THE COMPLEMENT LEVEL

- * **Me** will change to **Him/her**
- * **Us** will change to **Them**
- * **This** will change to **That**
- * **These** will change to **Those**

AT THE ADJUNCT LEVEL

- * **Now** will change to **Then**
- * **Here** will change to **There**

- * **Today** will change to **That day**
- * **Tomorrow** will change to **The following day**
- * **Yesterday** will change to **The previous day**
- * **Last week/year** will change to **The previous week/year**

Let us report this message indirectly:

I am in school now and I will come here tomorrow. Indirect speech = He said that he was in school then and he would go there the following day.

Note those words that have changed.

Model Question 1

Jane asked James (a) whether could she meet him later (b) could she meet him later (c) if she could meet him later (d) she could meet him later (e) that she could meet him later

Clue to answer. Read reported speech again.

Model Question 2

Don't study on the examination day. What did he tell you?

He told meon the examination day (a) no studying (b) don't study (c) not study (d) not to study (e) to not study

PLURAL CATEGORIES OF NOUNS

In this part, you will learn about the plural forms of certain categories of nouns.

A. PLURALIA TANTUMS

Pluralia tantums are words (nouns) that will necessarily end in **s**. When the **s** morpheme is removed, the words become incomplete and useless. They are the following: **annals, archives, arms**, (for war), **arrears, ashes, auspices, banns** (of marriage), **bowels, dregs, earnings, entrails, fireworks, funds, goods, guts, holidays, odds, outskirts, particulars, premises, quarters, headquarters, regards, remains, riches, spirits, stairs**, (flight of stairs) **surroundings, thanks, troops, tropics, wages, wits**.

You will notice that all of them end in an **s**. They cannot be without **s**.

Rules

1. They must always appear with **s** at the end.
2. All these nouns attract the plural verb (verb without **s**),
e.g. (i) The odds **are** against him. (not: **is**)
(ii) His looks **show** anger. (not: **shows**)

B. IRREGULAR PLURALS

Quantitative nouns: dozen, hundred, thousand, million, stone, (measurement) head etc are all under this category.

Rules

- (1) Even when a number, e.g. two, four, etc. comes before each of the quantitative nouns, no **s** shall be added to the quantitative noun, e.g. two hundred (not: two hundreds). Do you understand? Try with "thousand".

- (2) When no number comes before the quantitative noun, it takes an **s**, e.g. **Hundreds** of boys are here (Note that no number/figure comes before **hundreds**, so, it takes an **s**).

C. UNMARKED PLURALS

Cattle, clergy, folk, gentry, people, police, vermin, youth – all come under this category.

Rules

- (1) They will NOT take an **s** at the end to form their plurals, e.g. Youths X or Clergies X
- (2) When **people** means **nation** and there are two or more such **people**, (nation), **people** becomes **peoples**, e.g. The **peoples** of Ghana and Nigeria but, the **people** of Nigeria.
- (3) When **youth** refers to boys and girls generally, it will NOT take any **s**, e.g. The **youth** of nowadays (not, **youths**), but when **youth** refers to specific young people, youth may take an **s**, e.g. These two **youths** (specific reference) are hard working and it is different from **youth** in general concept (generic).
- (4) When, generally, any of these words is used, a plural verb must be used, e.g. The **vermin stay** alive. (not:stays).

D. SUMMATION PLURALS

These include: **shears, knickers, trousers, tights, flannels, scissors, scales, braces, suspenders, pliers, spectacles, shorts, pyjamas, glasses, pincers, binoculars, tweezers, pants, tongs and bellows**

Rules

- (1) All these words must always take an **s** after them otherwise, they will each be meaningless.
- (2) **A pair, two pairs**, etc. can be used before each to show number, e.g. **A pair** = one pair of glasses **lies** (not lie) on the table.

Note that when **pair** is used, the verb to follow it will depend on the number attached to the **pair**, e.g.

A (one) pair of scissors **looks** like shears.

It is "**looks**" singular verb because we have **a (one)** which is **singular**.

So, if we have **two pairs** of scissors, the next verb will be plural, i.e. **Two pairs** of scissors **look** like shears

E. OS PLURALS

The following words end with **os** to form their plurals:
Achipelago, banjo, buffalo, cargo, tornado, commando, motto, volcano, e.g. buffalos, cargos.

Note: They may also have **oes** as their plurals, e.g. **cargoes**.

F. OES PLURALS

Veto, hero, negro, echo, potato, torpedo, and embargo are to have **oes** only, to show their plurals, e.g.

heroes, not: heros

potatoes, not: potatos

G. PLURALS ENDING IN VES

Calf, elf, half, knife, leaf, life, loaf, self, sheaf, shelf, thief, wife, and wolf, e.g. **shelves, wives** (Treat the others the same way.)

H. + S AND + "VES" + PLURALS

The following can be pluralised in two ways:

(a) by just adding an **s**

(b) by ending them in **ves**

They include: **dwarf, handkerchief, hoof, scarf, wharf.**

Note: When **still life** refers to paintings, its plural is **still lifes** not **still lives**.

WORDS ENDING IN "F" WILL HAVE "S" PLURALS

I. The following words ending in **f** will take the addition of **s**, to make their plural: **cliff, roof, belief, proof, chief**, e.g. **roofs**

MUTATION

J. The following will only change their vowels to show plurality:

Foot /u/ Feet /i/

woman women

goose geese

mouse mice

tooth teeth

man men

EN PLURALS:

The following will end in **en** to show their plurals:

Brother - Brethren

Child - Children

Ox - oxen

Note: When we refer to members of the same religious organisation, **brethren** is the plural of **brother** but, if not religious, the plural of brother is **brothers**.

ANIMAL NAMES IN PLURALS

L. The following will not take any **s**, to make them plural: **fish, pike, trout, carp, deer, moose, grouse, sheep, cattle, plalce** and **salmon**, e.g. We caught some fish (not fishes). **Fishes** can be used when we have a variety.

The following animals will add **s** at the end to make them plural: **blrd, rabbit, hen, crab, welk, eagle, duck**.

M.

NOUNS OF QUANTITY

When no figure, e.g. one, ten, five, etc, comes before, the following should have an **s** to pluralise them: **hundred**, **thousand**, **million**, **dozen**, **head** (of cattle), **stone**, (British weighing system)

e.g. **Hundreds** of boys are here.

Dozens of women die yearly.

N:

APOSTATIC NOUNS

Some nouns that behave in two ways at the same time and which include the following can have singular or plural verbs after them: **species**, **headquarters**, **means**, **barracks**, e.g. The **means are** difficult. Compare: A series of lectures **have** been organised.

O:

FOREIGN PLURALS

The following plurals are words that are of, or, have, foreign origin. The foreign words may be from French, Latin, Greek, etc. They are being used today as English words.

Word

Origin

Foreign Plural

Criterion

Greek

Criteria

Phenomenon

Greek

Phenomena

Demon

Greek

Demons

Election

Greek

Elections

Neutron

Greek

Neutrons

Proton

Greek

Protons

Tempo

Italian

Tempos

Metropolis

"

Metropolises

Analysis

"

Analyses

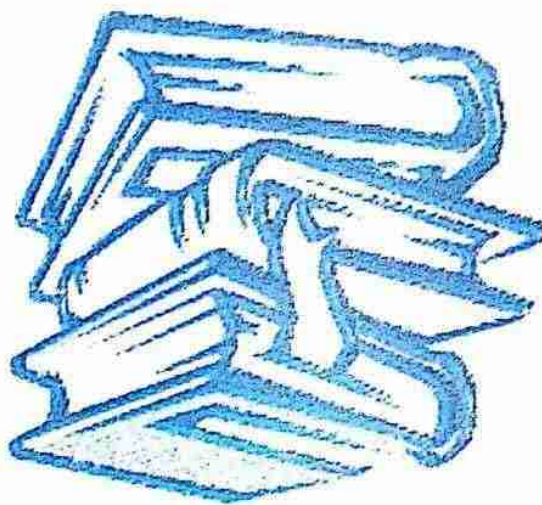
Axis

"

Basis	"	Bases
Crisis	"	Crises
Diagnosis	"	Diagnoses
Hypnosis	"	Hypnoses
Hypothesis	"	Hypotheses
Thesis	"	Theses
Oasis	"	Oases
Parenthesis	"	Parentheses
Synopsis	Greek	Synopses
Apex	Latin	Apices or apexes
Index	"	Indices or indexes
Vortex	"	Vortices or vortexes
Appendix	"	Appendices or appendixes
Matrix	"	Matrice or matrixes
Album	"	Albums
Chrysanthemum	"	Chrysanthemums
Museum	"	Museums
Forum	"	Forums
Stadium	"	Stadiums/ stadia
Ultimatum	"	Ultimatums
Aquarium	"	Aquariums
Medium	"	Mediums/media
Memorandum	"	Memorandums/ Memoranda
Symposium	"	Symposiums/symposia
Curriculum	"	Curricula
Addendum	"	Addenda

Bacterium	"	Bacteria
Corrigendum	"	Corrigenda
Desideratum	"	Desiderata
Erratum	"	Errata
Ovum	"	Ova
Stratum	"	Strata
Area	"	Areas
Dilemma	"	Dilemmas
Diploma	"	Diplomas
Drama	"	Dramas
Antenna	"	Antennas/antennae
Formula	"	Formulas/formulae
Nebula	"	Nebulae/nebulas
Vertebra	"	Vertebrae/vertebras
Alga	"	Algae
Alumna	"	Alumnae
Larva	"	Larvae
Bonus	"	Bonuses
Campus	"	Campuses
Chorus	"	Choruses
Circus	"	Circuses

A to Z of JAMB's
Use of English



SECTION TWO
ORAL FORMS: A Treatise of
ORAL ENGLISH APPLICATIONS

SPECIAL GUIDE TO ORAL FORMS

The Sounds of English: An Introduction

Under this aspect, we will discuss the sounds that are produced in English, each time we speak – particularly as these sounds are relevant to the Oral English Syllabus of the Joint Admissions and Matriculation Board and the various syllabi of international examination bodies.

We will not discuss the intricacies of **place** and **manner** of articulation (making speech). We will go to discuss the syllabus provisions, straight away. The syllabus recognises two aspects:

- (a) segmental features.
- (b) supra – segmental features.

The supra – segmental features have to do with such aspects as **stress**, **rhyme** and **intonation**, whereas the segmental features are responsible for moderating the quality of the utterances we make. Anyone who knows about the segmental but not the supra-segmental features is not yet a successful speaker of the English Language.

The Segmental Features

Every human language has its own letters which represent or form the alphabet. The letters **AEIOU** are **vowels** while the others between A and Z (excluding the vowels) are consonants.

These are just letters- not sounds. **Vowel SOUNDS** are commonly divided into diphthongs and monophthongs.

Five vowel letters represent **twenty vowel SOUNDS** in English speech.

VOWEL SOUNDS

MONOPHTHONGS

There are 12 monophthongs altogether, each represented with symbols as follows:

- | | | |
|----------|------|--|
| Vowel 1 | /i:/ | as in – sleep, need, read |
| Vowel 2 | /i/ | (short form of vowel 1) as in – hit, fill, little. |
| Vowel 3 | /e/ | as in – let, egg, net, thread. |
| Vowel 4 | /æ/ | as in – man, rag, batch. |
| Vowel 5 | /a:/ | as in –fart, cart, harm. |
| Vowel 6 | /ɔ/ | (It sounds like 'o') as in – ox, e.g. rod, box, odd. |
| Vowel 7 | /ɔ:/ | (the long form of 6 above) as in – tore, raw, caught. |
| Vowel 8 | /u/ | (this is a short vowel) as in–look, put |
| Vowel 9 | /u:/ | (the long form of 8 above) as in–rude, groom |
| Vowel 10 | /ʌ / | (this is a short vowel which sounds like 'a') as in – sun, cup, but. |
| Vowel 11 | /ɜ:/ | (this is a long but weak vowel), as in – girl, earth etc. |
| Vowel 12 | /ə/ | (a short and weak vowel) as in – around, about, matter. |

DIPHTHONGS

While Monophthongs consist of one sound each, a diphthong has two sounds that have been joined together as they are pronounced. You will notice that the first of the two sounds will gain more loudness than the second:

Vowel 13	/ei /	as in – day, ray, rald.
Vowel 14	/əu/	as in – know, go.
Vowel 15	/ai/	as in – mice, thigh, tie, eye.
Vowel 16	/au/	as in – cow, now, how.
Vowel 17	/ɔi/	as in – boy, oil, foll.
Vowel 18	/iə/	as in – rear, idea, here.
Vowel 19	/eə/	as in – hair, their, tear.
Vowel 20	/uə/	as in – sure, tour, poor.

CONSONANT SOUNDS

There are twenty-four consonant sounds. For teaching reasons, we may not mention the names given to each of these sounds but they are laid out and exemplified here.

/b/	as in	boy
/d/	as in	dog
/f/	as in	fan
/g/	as in	god
/h/	as in	hall
/dʒ/	as in	jug
/k/	as in	kite
/l/	as in	lamp
/m/	as in	man
/n/	as in	nose
/p/	as in	priest
/r/	as in	risk
/s/	as in	sink
/t/	as in	tear
/v/	as in	van
/w/	as in	wife
/j/	as in	yellow
/z/	as in	zebra
/tʃ/	as in	cheap
/ʃ/	as in	sheep
/dʒ/	as in	beige
/θ/	as in	thing
/ð/	as in	them
/ʊ/	as in	thing

Please note that whenever you find two slanting lines ' / ' they represent the pronunciation for a word. It may sometimes be ().

The following words and their pronunciation have been given to help you understand the pronunciation of the symbols (sounds) described:

VOWELS

/ ɔi /	- oil /ɔil/, boy /bɔi/, joy /dʒɔi /
/ iə /	- here /hiə/, idea /aidiə/, tear /tiə/, rear /riə/
/ eə /	- fair /feə/, hair /heə/, there /ðeə/
/ uə /	- sure /suə/, tour /tuə/, lure /luə/
/ au /	- cow /kau/, bow /bau/

CONSONANTS

Sounds	As in
/b/	boy /bɔi/, bed /bed/, tub /tʌb/, rub /rʌb/
/d/	dog /dɒg/, dig /dig/, god /gɒd/, paid /peid/
/f/	fee /fi:/, draft /dræft/
/g/	get /get/, give /giv/, rig /rig/
/h/	hail /heil/, house /haus/, hip /hip/, hut /hʌt/
/dʒ/	jug /dʒʌg/, joke /dʒəuk/
/k/	kill /kil/, keep /ki:p/, care /kiə/
/l/	club /klʌb/, flee /fli:/, light /lait/, look /luk/
/m/	man /mæn/, name /neim/, mean /mi:n/
/n/	name /neim/, keen /ki:n/, new /nju:/
/p/	park /pa:k/, leap /li:p/, pit /pit/, grip /grip/
/r/	prime /praim/

/s/	cement /siment/, scene /si:n/, press /pres/
/t/	part /pa:t/, pit /pit/, tea /ti:/
/v/	van /væn/, live /laiv/, vice /vais/
/w/	white /wait/, we /wi/, wind /wind/, wet /wet/
/j/	yam /jæm/, youth/ ju:θ/
/z/	zip /zip/, zoo /zu:/, lazy /leizi/
/tʃ/	chalk /tʃɔ:k/, chief /tʃi:f/
/ʃ/	she /ʃi:/, shy /ʃai/
/ʒ/	beige /beiz/, pleasure /pleʒə/
/θ/	thing /θiŋ/, tenth /tenθ/
/ð/	they /ðei/, thus /ðʌs/
/ɪŋ/	thing /θi:ŋ/, sing /siŋ/

Now, try to pronounce the following and identify the differences. The pronunciation for each, is in front of it.

VOWELS

bad	/ bæd /,	bird	/ bɜ:d /,	bud	/ bʌd /
cat	/ kæt /,	cart	/ kɑ:t /		
cot	/ kɒt /,	cut	/ kʌt /,	court	/ kɔ:t /
had	/ hæd /,	hard	/ hɑ:d /		
hot	/ hɒt /,	hut	/ hʌt /,	heart	/ hɑ:t /
pill	/ pil /,	peel	/ pi:l /		
pat	/ pæt /,	part	/ pa:t /		

CONSONANTS

wish	/ wiʃ /,	which	/ witʃ /
cease	/ si:s /,	seize	/ si:z /
both	/ bæuθ /,	boat	/ bæut /
lose	/ lu:z /,	loose	/ lu:s /
glass	/ glæs /,	glaze	/ gleiz /
house (n)	/ haus /,	house (vb)	/ hauz /
offer	/ ɔfə /,	over	/ əuvə /
prize	/ praiz /,	price	/ prais /
tree	/ tri: /,	three	/ θri: /
buzz	/ bʌz /,	bus	/ bʌs /
feather	/ feðə /,	fetter	/ fetə /
pat	/ pæt /,	bat	/ bæt /
pit	/ pit /,	fit	/ fit /
fan	/ fæn /,	van	/ væn /
sheep	/ ʃi:p /,	cheap	/ tʃi:p /
thus	/ ðʌs /,	does	/ dɔz /
they	/ ðei /,	day	/ dei /
sell	/ sel /,	shell	/ ʃel /
son	/ sʌn /,	shun	/ ʃʌn /
true	/ tru: /,	through	/ θru: /
tens	/ lenz /,	tense	/ tens /

Now, in case you are to undergo a practical, oral examination, you should be able to listen and differentiate between sounds before you write them down.

NOTE: This is to remind you that where you find double dots as in full colon (:) after a symbol, it means you will prolong the sound, e.g.

Cart / kɑ:t / = kaat

Good / gu:d / = guud

STRESS IN ENGLISH

In many African languages, some methods are used to mark the words for pronunciation purposes. This marking on top or below the word will show which part should be pronounced louder than other parts.

Stress cannot be described without first discussing **the syllable**.

All words in the English language have at least one syllable. One part of a word may be pronounced differently from the other part(s). A syllable may therefore be defined as part of a word that can be produced at one heart-beat.

In every syllable, there must be a vowel sound. For example, "interdenominationalism" (the longest word in the dictionary) can be syllabified as follows: **in-ter-de-no-mi-na-tio-na-li-sm** = ten syllables.

A word may have one syllable, known as **MONOSYLLABLE**; two syllables – **BISYLLABLE**, more than two – **POLYSYLLABLE**, e.g.

Monosyllable	-	man, boy, girl, good
Bisyllable	-	Mon/day, Eng/lish, fa/ther, e/ffort.
Polysyllable	-	Beau/ti/ful, per/so/nal, re/co/ver.

Now, back to stress. When there is more than one syllable in a word, one syllable will be pronounced louder than the other. For example, in the following words, the louder of the two syllables has been written in bold capital letters:

LAW-yer, **SPEAK**-er, en-**DURE**, re-**VENGE**. The syllable that is pronounced louder than the other(s) is called **STRESSED** or **ACCENTED SYLLABLE**. The part that is not pronounced loudly is called **UNSTRESSED** or **UNACCENTED SYLLABLE**.

HOW TO DETERMINE WHERE TO PUT STRESS

When a word carries a stress, the stress is often shown by the (') symbol, e.g. 'tailor.

First, determine how many syllables are in the word. Here, there are two, tai/lor.

Now that 'tai has a stress, it means tai is the only syllable that carries that stress. The other syllable will not be pronounced loudly.

In Yoruba language, there are tone marks to show the pronunciation of words. The syllables in a Yoruba word can carry a low (do), mid (re) or high (mi) tone.

So, to pronounce awure, it must sound;

(do-mi-re)

(a-wu-re) =awure.

Olodumare =re-mi-do-re-do

(re-mi-do-re-do)

(O-lo-du-ma-re) = Olodumare.

Ipata =do-mi-mi

(do-mi-mi)

(i-pa-ta) = ipata.

The problem most Africans have in pronouncing English words with the right stress is that of "linguistic interference". This means that, a Yoruba man may likely pronounce bread (an English word) with the syllable structure of Yoruba, thus:

mi-mi-do = bu-re-di

Whereas, it is a one-syllable word in English: bread /bred/

So, you need to carefully learn the English stress patterns.

Find below, a list of bisyllabic words that take stress on the first syllable.

CATEGORY I (a)

answer	farmer	factor	gather	
speaker	nation	batter	vomit	magic
victory	speaker	labour	hunter	cattle
				lower

CATEGORY I (b)

The following are also two-syllable words that have their stress on the second syllable:

a'bout	a'go	fifteen	re'play
co'mmit	e'lect	re'mit	be'fore
con'cern	co'nnect	im'pure	to'day

CATEGORY II

There are some words that take the stress on the first syllable if used as a noun and on the second when used as a verb. They include:

VERB

ex**P**ORT
con**V**ERT
im**P**ORT
con**V**ICT
de**S**ERT
ex**T**RACT
re**C**ORD
in**C**REASE
in**S**ULT
ob**J**ECT

NOUN

EX**p**ort
CON**v**ert
IM**p**ort
CON**v**ict
DE**s**ert
EX**t**ract
RE**c**ord
IN**c**rease
IN**s**ult
Ob**j**ect.

perMIT
preSENT
reBEL
reCORD
miNUTE
auGUST
subJECT
surVEY
proTEST
comBINE
comPRESS
conCERT
conDUCT
conSORT
conTRACT
freQUENT
proDUCE
proGRESS
proJECT
reFUSE
segMENT

PERmit
PREsent
Rebel
REcord
MInute
AUgust
SUBject
SURvey
PROtest
COMbine
COMpress
CONcert
CONduct
CONsort
CONtract
FREquent
PROduce
PROgress
PROject
REfuse
SEGment

CATEGORY III (a)

In three-syllable words, the stress may fall on the first, second or third syllable. Here, the stress falls on the first:

PHO/to/graph
IN/sti/tute

MI/ni/mum

BRO/ther/hood

MO/ther/ly

HOPE/less/ly

CATEGORY III (b)

Second syllable stressed in three-syllable words are as follows:

ope/ RA /tor	pa/ TER /nal	de/ MO /tion
a/ PPREN /tice	a/ BAN /don	to/ MO /rrow
hi/ LLA /rious	bom/ BAS /tic	re/ DUN /dant

CATEGORY III (c)

Third syllable stressed in trisyllabic words are as follows:

un/der/ STAND	un/der WEIGHT	over STATE
wa/rran/ TEE	bri/ga/ DIER , etc.	

CATEGORY IV

Number Stressing

- (a) Teen numbers (stress on the second syllable), e.g.
thir**TEEN**, four**TEEN**, fif**TEEN**, six**TEEN**, seven**TEEN**,
eigh**TEEN**, nine**TEEN**.
- (b) Numbers in tens (stress on the first syllable) e.g.
THIRTY, **FORTY**, **FIFTY**, **SIXTY**, **SEVENTY**, **EIGHTY**, **NINETY**.

CATEGORY V

Change in stress can occur as a word changes from one class to another. Here, a noun e.g. "economy" can change to an adjective "economic", "compile" (verb) to "compilation" (noun). When a change so occurs, the stress usually changes. Some words in this category are:

compute (vb) -	com PUTE	computation (n) -	compu TATION
compile (vb) -	com PILE	compilation (n) -	compi LATION
resign (vb) -	re SIGN	resignation (n) -	resig NATION
explain (vb) -	ex PLAIN	explanation (n) -	expla NATION

politics	(n) - POL itics	political	(adj.) - po L itical
nation	(n) - N ation	nationality	(n) - Natio N ality
compute	(vb) - com P UTE	computation	(n) - compu T ation.

CATEGORY VI

Stressing Compound Words

- (a) When noun compound – words are to be stressed, the stress falls on the first syllable:

Auditor-General, **M**Other-in-law, **P**Ost-Office,
COMmander-in Chief, **V**ICE-Principal, **H**OUse-Prefect,
HEAD-of State, **G**IRL-guide,
BYE-Law, **O**N-looker, **B**Y-stander,
DEAF-mute, **M**ANaging-Director, etc.

- (b) When verb compound-words are to be stressed, the stress falls on the second syllable:

over**S**TRESS, under**P**AY, out**C**LASS, back**D**ATE, under**G**O, etc.

STRESSING SENTENCES

All along, we have been discussing stressing of individual words. If you have been given a sentence or even a passage to read, how do you recognise the words to stress?

The rule is that you will stress the **open class items**, including **nouns, verbs, adverbs and adjectives**.

You should avoid stressing **closed system items** which include: **pronouns, prepositions, conjunctions and articles** (the, a).

Now, let us try to stress this clause:

The **man** in the **class** is my **uncle**.

The **MAN** in the **CLASS** is my **UNCLE**.

The beautiful girl knows me: The **BEAUTIFUL GIRL KNOWS** me.

However, if emphasis is to be shown, closed system items can be stressed, e.g.

A: Did you say that man is on the bed?

B: No, he is **UNder** the table.

"under" is stressed here to emphasise where the man is.

RULES FOR STRESSING WORDS AND SENTENCES

1. **DO NOT** put a stress on any of the following:

(a) **PRONOUNS and POSSESSIVES**, including:
he, she, it, we, you, they, him, her, me, us, them,
this, these, those, that, his, her, its, my, your, our,
their.

(b) **AUXILIARY VERBS**, including:
can-could, may-might, shall-should, will-would, must,
need, dare, is, was, are, were, am, has, have, had.

(c) **ARTICLES**, including:
a, an, the.

(d) **PREPOSITIONS** – Monosyllable prepositions, e.g.
in, on, at, for, by, with, cannot be stressed. However,
occasionally, prepositions with more than one syllable
may be stressed e.g. be**FORE**, **UNder**, a**GAInST**,
a**ROUND**, a**TER**.

(e) **CONJUNCTIONS and CORRELATIVES**, including:
and, but, either, neither.

General note-These items can be stressed, however, to show emphasis or contrast.

2. When in a clause/sentence, if **the** is pronounced, it will be /ðə/ when it comes **before** a consonant letter-word, e.g.
The (ðə) man/boy/cow.
But if **the** comes before a vowel letter-word, it is pronounced (ði), e.g.
The (ði) elephant, orange, umbrella, Idiot.

INTONATION

Mood is the feeling you experience at a particular time. At one time, you may be angry, at another you may be happy or even wish to ask a question. It is therefore clear that the PITCH – the level of your voice – will not be the same when you ask a yes-no question and when you say what you know (as in a declarative statement). This variation of the level of pitch is termed INTONATION.

Intonation is basically of two-types – RISING and FALLING.

RISING INTONATION

The rising intonation is that tone that rises from a low pitch slowly until it gets to the highest level. It is used for the following:

- (a) **For making requests**
 - i. Can I see you, please?
 - ii. May we sit down?
- (b) **For asking a question whose answer is “Yes” or “No”**
 - i. Do you know him?
 - ii. Are they friends?
- (c) **For making controversial statements or statements of surprise**
 - i. That boy is likely to win.
 - ii. We didn't know he could slap the teacher.
- (d) **To ask the first of two questions**
 - i. Will you see me or go to the market first?

FALLING INTONATION

This represents the pitch that falls. Its functions include:

- (a) **For making imperative statements (commands)**
 - i. Walk out of here!
 - ii. Report the case immediately!

(b) **For asking questions starting with Interrogative adverbs and pronouns (WH questions)**

- i. **Why** are you here?
- ii. **Who** saw you?
- iii. **How** many are they?
- iv. **Where** did they go?

(c) **For making declarative statements**

- i. She is beautiful.
- ii. The boy speaks English well.

TYPES OF QUESTIONS YOU SHOULD EXPECT IN ORAL ENGLISH EXAMINATIONS

An Oral English Test can be conducted both verbally and on paper (written). The following question types are common:

1. Word-class questions

A list of words will be given and stressed. You are to identify whether each word is a noun, verb, adjective etc. e.g.

REcord (n), reCORD (vb), imPORT (vb), IMport (n)

2. Syllable-identification questions

Here, a list of words will be given a – e. Four of them will have stress on the first syllable. (But the stress will not be put on any) You will be required to identify the word that is stressed on the second syllable, e.g.

A	B	C	D	E
enter	promote	dearer	liver	father

Which of them carries a second-syllable stress?

enter	-	(first syllable stressed)
promote	-	(second syllable stressed)
dearer	-	(first syllable stressed)
liver	-	(first syllable stressed)
father	-	(first syllable stressed)

So, "promote" is the answer.

3. Odd-one-out type of questions

This type of question is set from the perspective of pronunciation. You will be required to recognise the one whose pronunciation is different from the others. When you are faced with this type of question, you must consider certain things, such as:

i. Consonants

They can occur at various positions – initial, medial, final, e.g.

A	B	C	D
pack	park	carp	rack

You will discover that the final consonant in A, B and D is /k/ whereas in C it is /p/.

ii. Symbols

This means that the difference between symbols of the sounds must be watched, e.g.

i. there /ðeər/, them /ðem/, theme /θi:m/, they /ðei/

ii. thick /θik/, thee /ði:/, they /ðei/.

Practise with the following:

	A	B	C	D
1.	kill	call	cell	com
2.	fire	hire	fine	higher
3.	tree	three	treat	trip
4.	seal	sick	seem	seed
5.	deep	dream	drape	dreary
6.	check	shock	shirt	ship
7.	sketch	skeptic	skirt	scepter
8.	scale	skin	sketch	scepter
9.	gown	down	mown	clown
10.	push	fish	wish	pitch

4. Consonant-cluster questions

Consonant cluster refers to a situation where up to two or more consonants follow each other in a word. To determine the clusters, it is not the spelling of the word itself that shows them. So we must first write out the pronunciation of the word. You still remember what consonant sounds are.

Let us see some examples of consonant clusters:

Word	Pronunciation	Consonant cluster
student	/ stjudent /	stj (initial position)
new	/ nju: /	nj (initial position)
sculpts	/ sk ^ lpts /	pts (final position)
next	/ nekst /	kst (final position)
shrink	/ ʃrink /	nk (final position)

Candidates are advised to study pronunciation patterns in standard English pronouncing dictionaries, so that they can recognise where there are clusters of consonant sounds. Remember, the cluster cannot be determined by looking at the word itself but at its pronunciation.

Find below, words that have two, three, four consonants.

Note:

You cannot find a word with more than three consonant sounds that occur at the beginning, and a maximum of four, at the end of an English word.

The structure of a syllable is:

C + C + C + V + C + C + C + C, also written as:

(C03) V(C04) also written as (CCC) V (CCCC).

Now, attempt to indicate the syllable structure of the following words:

Clusters of Two Consonants

Example: forks / fɔ:ks / structure = (C) v (CC)

1. maps / / Structure = _____
2. rend / / Structure = _____

3. hand / / Structure = _____
4. rant / / Structure = _____

Clusters of Three Consonants

Example: ants /ænts/ structure = V (CCC)

1. camps / / Structure = _____
2. mixed / / Structure = _____
3. jumped / / Structure = _____
4. masks / / Structure = _____

Clusters of Four Consonants

Example: glimpsed /glimpst/ structure = (CC)V (CCCC)

1. prompts / / Structure = _____
2. exempts / / Structure = _____
3. temps / / Structure = _____
4. sculpts / / Structure = _____

5. Silent – letter questions

You may be given a list of words and asked to identify the sounds that will not be pronounced in each such word. The sound that can be omitted may occur at the initial, medial or final position e.g.

apos(t)le	(medial)	(g)nash	(initial),
colum(n)	(final)	cas(t)le	(medial),
(p)neumonia	(initial)	phle(g)m	(medial),

(k)now	(initial)	of(t)en	(medial),
(p)sychology	(initial)	(p)salm	(initial),
si(g)n	(medial)	thin(g)	(final),
bom(b)	(final)	ta(l)k	(medial),
(h)onest	(initial)	resi(g)n	(medial),
yo(l)k	(medial)	su(b)tle	(medial).

6. Test of markers of inflection

When a word moves from its base form, e.g. take (vb) to "takes", the word is said to have an inflectional ending.

Now, questions can be asked on that, in oral presentation or in written form. You will be asked to show the appropriate pronunciation for inflectionals ending in "s" and those ending in "ed" past tense/ past participle.

The treatise is divided into two: "s" and "ed" pronunciation.

(A) S – Plural inflection: pronunciation

Where "s" shows plural, e.g.

boys, houses, glasses etc., the last pluralising "s" is not always pronounced as /s/. It can, at different times, be pronounced as /z/, /iz/, /s/.

Rules

- i. If you have /k, f, t, p,/ sounds as in: brooks, staffs, pots, and cups coming before the last "s", the "s" after those sounds will be pronounced as /s/. Pronounce the words above.
- ii. If you have any of the following consonant sounds plus "s" at the end, the "s" should be pronounced as /iz/. They include: /dʒ, tʃ, s, z, ʃ/ as in:

judges, churches, washes, buzzes, hisses – respectively.

So, look for words that end in those sounds, then put an “s” (or **es**) and pronounce everything together, ending the pronunciation with /z/.

- iii. When “s” is added at the back of a word that ends with the following consonant sounds: /b, d, g, l, m, n, v, / the “s” is pronounced as /z/ as in: cabs, cards, rags, things, bells, calls, dons, and moves.

(B) **Past – tense marker inflection: pronunciation**

– **ed** is usually added to regular verbs to form their past tense / past participle. It is not at all times that the **ed** will be pronounced as /d/. At times, it will be pronounced /t/ or /ɪd/.

Rules

- i. If the sound that comes before a past tense marker is either /t/ or /d/ as in “draft-ed” and “mind-ed”, the “ed” should be pronounced /ɪd/, e.g.

wanted, waited, lifted – are some words whose “ed” will be /ɪd/.

- ii. If the sound that comes before the past tense marker is a voiced consonant or a vowel, then, pronounce the “ed” as /d/, e.g.

begged = /begd/

prayed = /preɪd/

- iii. If the sound that comes before the past tense marker is a voiceless consonant, as in slap-ed, pass-ed, then, the “ed” or past tense marker will be pronounced /t/ as

slapped = /slæpt/

passed = /pa:st/

Word stress questions

7.

Here, as it has been pointed out, you may be asked to identify where the stress falls – in all the syllables that constitute a word. Even if a word has five syllables, as in:

“examination”, “international”, “administrative”; you should know which syllable is stressed, e.g. exami**N**ation, inter**N**ational.

Read more on syllables and stress.

8. Sentence stress questions

You have been warned that whether in written form or when you are asked to read a passage, there are certain words you should avoid stressing – the closed system items (pronouns, prepositions, conjunctions, articles and interjections). All other parts of speech found in the sentences – noun, verb, adverb and adjective – can be stressed.

Stress this:

The boy and the girl live in Jamaica but do not know each other.

9. Contrastive stress questions

Here, you may be given different statements/questions and emphasis will be placed on different aspects of what that statement is about, e.g.

1. I **SAW** the thief. (Because “SAW” is stressed, it shows that, I did not just hear the rumour but actually **SAW**.)
2. I saw the **THIEF** (I saw the thief – **not any other person**.)
3. I saw the thief **YESTERDAY**.
(I saw the thief – **not today or last week but yesterday**.)

Now, try the following:

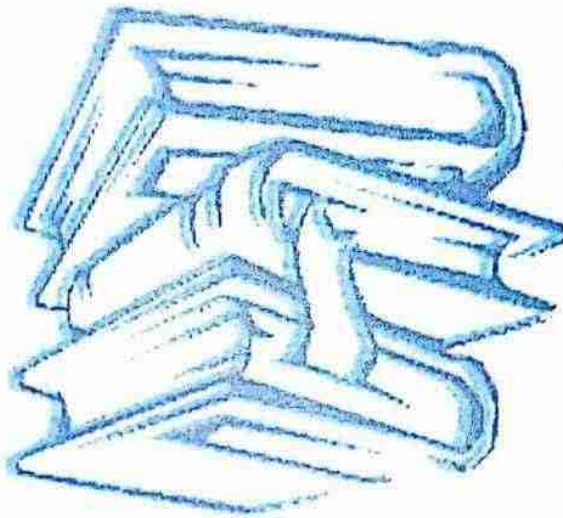
1. I **STOLE** his book = ?
2. I stole **HIS** book = ?
3. I stole his **BOOK** = ?
4. I stole his Book = ?

What does each of the statements mean?

10. Intonation questions

Here, you will be tested on how to read / identify a question with **wh-**, a command, a declarative statement etc. Now, turn the pages back and learn the pattern under INTONATION.

A to Z of JAMB's
Use of English



SECTION THREE
COMPREHENSION

WHAT COMPREHENSION IS NOT and WHAT IT IS

We are all very familiar with different situations when we have to listen to someone and act on his/her instruction or we even give an instruction and expect someone to act on it. Comprehension could be described, therefore, as the mental relationship between two people.

Such a relationship in communication can take different dimensions. At one time, it may be from a newscaster on television or radio to us at home; from a teacher to his/her students or a speaker to his/her audience. At another level, it could be from an author to the reader – as it is now. In all, information is passed from one person to another but the difference is the medium through which this information is disseminated. Even between a special teacher and his/her students, the deaf and dumb, for example, symbolic interactionism or representational communicationism – the idea of using symbols and signs to communicate – is what is used. And it would simply be a surprise to listeners that a deaf student could accurately carry out instructions given by the teacher.

So, basically, we recognize one fact: that every form of communication – be it electronic (such as television broadcast) or graphic (such as reading what an author has written) or speech (such as listening to a teacher in class) – involves **coding** and **decoding**. **Coding** is the system of passing information whereas **decoding** is the analysis and understanding of the information passed by the encoder.

There is therefore a necessity for the decoder to find adequate means of “decoding” any information. Candidates fail to understand the set passages in an examination because they are not able to find adequate means of decoding the message passed by the passage writer.

Gone are those days when passages such as, 'Mister Giwa is a Trader' were set. Those kind of passages were meant for elementary learners but at the pre-University level, passages will be more difficult. But what on earth makes the passages difficult? You should know right away that, once you fail to understand a passage very well, you **WILL NOT** arrive at the correct answer. We will discuss methods that you can adopt for analysing even the most difficult of passages.

Comprehension does not mean looking for answers. It does not mean guessing your answers. Comprehension does not mean passing your eyes swiftly over words of a passage. Comprehension means, coming to terms with all that the coder is passing to the decoder, such that, after reading the passage (in the case of candidates reading passages in an examination), the reader will be able to state, what he or she has read, idea-for-idea. It means, you should be able to tell somebody about all the basic facts of that passage without looking back in the passage.

SOURCES OF COMPREHENSION PASSAGES

When question moulders field some passages before you in the examination hall, think first about the source. There are two possible broad sources: original and adaptation.

Original: You could be given a passage specifically written by a good user of the English Language, for the purpose of the examination. He may write about his experiences, an event that took him by surprise a year or two years ago; he may even write about the situation – economic or political – in his country. His ideas are not restricted.

For example, UME 1993 passage III:

Model Question 1

When I set out for London, little did I suspect that I was not on a journey to God's own city where harmony reigned supreme. So used to the frenzied life of Lagos was I that I had come to associate that city with everything that was chaotic, and there was no doubt in my mind that Lagos was one giant symbol of our backwardness. As the plane taxied its way out of the tarmac of our national airport, I heaved a sigh of relief, not so much because I was leaving my own country as that I was being relieved of the tension that had possessed me during those tense hours in the untidy lounge. I had felt so uneasy, my thoughts racing from one uncertainty to another. But I was at last air-borne, moving away from the whole uncertainty, from the whole load of fear, towards a place which I supposed would be an El Dorado.

Everything that happened in the plane passed through my eyes like pictures on the screen. The white air hostess who instructed me on how to use the safety belt was an angel. What with her beauty, her pretty blue dress, and her ever-smiling face. The same lady of the air served me snacks and supper. Another angel, whose queenly voice came through an invisible public address system, dished out occasional information on the progress of our journey. I had never felt so relaxed, and my jolted heartbeats, each time the plane took what appeared like a sudden brief descent, did not matter. When eventually we were set for landing, the anxiety that came over me was almost thrilling. What was the wonderland going to be like? So overwhelmed was I that I almost lost consciousness of what happened thereafter.

But I would never forget the shock that greeted me when we arrived in the tube station and boarded a train to behold the sea of white faces and the furtive glances from apparently indifferent co-passengers. I believe that the nostalgic feeling for Lagos which later became part of my life all my days in London began at this point.

Adaptation: You could equally be given an extract from a novel. A part of a Science, Religion, History or Government book may be culled. Adaptations are of two types: partial and complete.

There is partial adaptation if just a part of a long prose is brought out and used as your comprehension passage, for example UME, 1985 passage V.

Model Question 2

The land was ready and ploughed, waiting for the crops. At night, the earth was alive with insects singing and rustling about in search of food. But suddenly, by mid-November, the rain fled away: the rain-clouds fled away and left the sky bare. The sun danced dizzily in the sky, with a strange cruelty. Each day, the land was covered in a haze of mist as the sun sucked up the last drop of moisture out of the earth. The family sat down in despair, waiting and waiting. Their hopes had run so high; the goats had started producing milk. It was impossible to plant the corn, maize, pumpkin and water-melon seeds in the dry earth. They sat the whole day in the shadow of the huts and even stopped thinking, for the rain had fled away. Only the children were quite happy in their little world. They carried on with their game of making house like their mother and chattered to each other in light, soft tones. They made children from sticks around which they tied rags, and scolded them severely in an exact imitation of their own mother. Their voices could be heard scolding all day long: "You stupid thing, when I send you to draw water, why do you spill half of it out of the bucket?" "You stupid thing! can't you mind the porridge pot without letting the porridge burn?" Then, they would beat the rag-dolls on their bottoms with severe expressions.

The adults paid no attention to this; their nerves were stretched to breaking point waiting for the rain to fall out of the sky. Nothing was important beyond that. All their animals had been sold during

the bad years to purchase food, and of all their herd only two goats were left. It was the women of the family who finally broke down under the strain of waiting for rain.

Taken from Bessie Head's *The Collector of Treasures*

Complete adaptation is when material written and already published (such as an article) by someone is produced in its complete form with no subtraction, addition or embellishments. If it is an adapted passage, it will be indicated at the bottom of the passage. If this is not done, then it is original. If you know the source of the passage you are dealing with, it helps greatly in your step toward arriving safely at the correct answer.

In passage III UME, 1993, you have discovered the ease of the use of language in the process of giving you an original passage. While reading the passage, did you understand all the points made by the writer? Can you now tell somebody about all you read, without looking back in the passage?

In passage V of 1985 (above), the acknowledgement at the bottom, of the passage clearly shows you that this passage is not of the original stock.

SUBJECT AREAS IN COMPREHENSION

What may an author or writer not write about? There are just few. A writer may not write obscene things such as vulgar events, pornographic experience or a fantastic sexual conference held with somebody sometime ago.

A comprehension passage may discuss religion, science - including agriculture, health care, technology; it may discuss sports or arts or leisure such as general events once witnessed. A passage may narrate an event or describe a person. The story as it is narrated is called **SUBJECT MATTER**. Note this: passages may be written

in form of an argument, in narrative essay form, in form of speech or in the straight form of an article.

What is the **SUBJECT MATTER** in the following passage; what is the blow-by-blow, step-by-step narration of events in the passage? (UME 1981 passage I)

Model Question 1

It was on a Sunday afternoon that I saw the lorry standing in front of the post office. I had seen it long before my brother saw it, but it was he who said to me, "Don't you think it odd that the post office should be open this afternoon? What do you think is happening?", "Come round the corner, out of sight, and let's watch," I answered. My brother Michael was younger than me, so I kept him behind me, and peering round the corner I told him what I saw. "There are four men coming out, carrying a very heavy iron box." "Oh!" I exclaimed, "It's a safe," I think. "They're burglars," said my brother, who was full of suspicion. "One of them has fallen over," I said; "the safe is too heavy for them." "You go and fetch the police," said my brother, "and I'll stay here and watch." "No, you go and get them," I replied, because I wanted to see what was going to happen. My brother ran off and then, suddenly, a man came running out of the post office, shouting, "Hurry! hurry! Get it on the lorry!" he joined the first four and they managed to get the safe up on to the back of the lorry. When they had done this, the man who had shouted got into the driver's seat, but the lorry would not start. Just then, my brother came back with three policemen. To cut a long story short, the men were all arrested and my brother and I had to go and give evidence before a magistrate. The men went to prison, of course, in the end, but you should have seen the face of the leader - it was contorted with rage - when he learned that the safe they had managed to steal was empty, and all the money was in the bank.

It has been stressed that the basic and cardinal aim of reading a passage is coming to terms with what the writer intends to pass on to the reader. There is therefore the need to read effectively so that no important detail is left out.

It is important to note that, once you start to read, you read for meaning. When you read, you read for discovery and, because of this, the reading should be done with concentration.

CONSTRAINTS TO EFFECTIVE READING

Many candidates usually come out of examination halls only to say, "Oh-if only I had understood the passage! The questions were simple, but I didn't understand the last paragraph." The major constraints have to do with the reader's background in language (that is, he or she may not have been brought up well with the English Language). It will therefore be unthinkable that such a reader will grasp the various language styles of the author and understand the passage. This is a fundamental problem that cannot easily be solved.

The second problem is psychological, that is, distraction of different dimensions. It is basically difficult for a reader to comprehend a passage or a message if he or she came into the examination hall with a troubled mind or is in an excessively happy mood. Once in the examination hall, therefore, a reader should release his/her mind from the weighty knot of excessive happiness or sadness. The mind should also be curbed from extraneous thoughts at that moment.

We will describe the things (within a passage) that usually make the passage difficult. The background and psychological problems described above are factors which are external and internal factors (constraints) will be discussed.

HOW TO READ A PASSAGE EFFECTIVELY

Skimming and scanning

What is skimming and what is scanning? A reader reads slowly because he or she is not sure of what the focus should be during a reading session. A JAMB candidate needs to develop the ability to locate the main ideas of a reading selection quickly if he or she is to read with good understanding. Skimming and scanning come in handy. These skills can help candidates read with great ease and also assist them in the understanding of the passage.

Skimming

Skimming means quickly looking for the main idea(s) of the passage. This involves an extremely fast reading through a passage to locate the main ideas in it. What the reader finds out during skimming is still general and can be more detailed. This method can also be used in determining the focus of periodicals or dailies when a reader has no patience to go the whole hog reading through the material. Large parts of the text are not read at all because skimming is the selective learning-out of parts of a comprehensive material. Can you now attempt to read parts of a passage and be able, after this, to determine what the subject matter is?

Scanning

Scanning means reading fast at the same time, getting full meaning of the passage. This is a more detailed fast reading during which specific items like words, facts or details are examined. The reader will find this a very useful skill for learning and mastering technical and specialized terminologies and registers.

PRACTICE

Here is a passage below. What you want to do is to read with the skimming method (just passing your eyes swiftly across, trying to determine what the passage is about (subject matter). Two, read the same passage (below) with the scanning method or skill, taking note slowly when doing this.

Model Question 1

It is customary nowadays among fashionable ladies and gentlemen to acquire strange and sometimes quaint clothes which are scarcely ever used. Sometimes, it may be an approaching festival; sometimes, a two-hour ceremony and sometimes, to honour a dead colleague - something triggers off the modern craze to sew new materials whose use does not outlast the moment of craze. And so, people who just occupy small apartments in their **parents'** homes, or have rented one room in a densely peopled house find that more than two-thirds of their rooms are filled with bongo trousers which they cannot wear, worn out jeans which stink, or specially made clothes for occasions that are not recurrent.

Although plagued by the problem of school fees for their children, parents have had to swallow their own phlegm and honour their children who need special clothes for important events. Newly employed youths soon find that their comrades are getting married, and a new and special attire must be used to grace the occasion. University students see matriculation ceremonies or induction ceremonies into club membership as special reasons to make new attire which - you may be sure - they would not wear on another occasion that parallels the one for which these clothes were made.

Medical doctors may soon find another cause for the incidence of high blood pressure among the youth. The desire to acquire new clothes is one strong possible cause, but a more subtle one which haunts like a ghost is the problem of choice of what to wear. The youth have so stuffed their apartments, wardrobes, drawers and trunks with so many clothes that the greatest problem they face is the choice of what to wear.

USING THEORIES TO SIMPLIFY A DIFFICULT COMPREHENSION PASSAGE

You have not been able to arrive at correct answers either because you usually do not understand the contents of the passage or because there are identical answers. These are no problems at all since there are scientific theories that you can apply.

To be able to understand a difficult comprehension passage, use the following three theories (note that, if there is even a little thing that you do not understand about the passage, you may not arrive at the correct answer; you must understand everything):

1. **the chemistry theory**
2. **the psychoanalytic theory**
3. **the cause and effect theory**

1. **The Chemistry Theory:** As the name suggests, this theory acts in line with the principle of chemistry. Chemistry itself is the study of behaviour of different elements or components, putting them together and watching out for the outcome or results of such elements. What are those elements (things) packaged in a comprehension passage and which you must analyse before you can understand the passage? They are: (a) subject matter, (b) theme, (c) lexical items, (d) extragrammatical items.

- (a) **Subject Matter:** Subject Matter is what the passage discusses. Does the passage discuss how a Palm-wine tapper was conscripted into the army by some fierce-looking soldiers or does it discuss how Olumba attended a village meeting where he was chosen to lead a group of guards for the village stream? Whatever the story told in the passage, is the subject matter. You must find this out.

- (b) **Theme:** Theme is the major lesson which the story teaches with the passage (subject matter). For example, a passage discusses a man who once had thousands of everything that man could have – vehicles, wives, children, houses – and in the twinkling of an eye, everything was gone, destroyed or lost. He kept on thinking positive without complaining, although the pain inflicted on him as a result of his losses was unimaginable. In a little while, more just like magic, everything he lost was replaced a hundred-fold, returning virile smiles to his lips.

What do you think the lesson about the story of this man is intended to teach? Remember that, first, the story as it is told is the subject matter. The lesson it teaches is the theme. The theme is optimism or courage. You must determine the theme of each passage. (Use the 1982 passage III below to practise subject matter and theme.)

Model Question 1

I was on top of one of my palm trees yesterday, tapping the tree and collecting the wine for the morning, when I saw two soldiers at the foot of the tree. They made signs at me, so I concluded that they wanted my palm wine. On descending from the tree, I gave them the wine to sample, as it is customary. Not only did they drain all the wine in the calabash, but they also said they had come to conscript me into the army. I asked them whether they wanted me or somebody else, they said they had come for me. I asked them whether an enemy sent them or they came on their own. To cut it short, they said I was wasting their time as they had to catch twenty men that day. Only a foolish man willingly disobeys armed soldiers. I told them I had something very important to say.

"Say it, then," one of them cut in impatiently, looking at his watch. It was approaching midday, by which time it was considered unsafe to drive around in a car for fear of enemy planes which had learnt to strafe individual vehicles on the highway.

"Yes, what I want to say is simple," I said. "My first son, the boy who should have succeeded me when I died, joined the army voluntarily and with my full backing. He was a brilliant boy, always first in his class. He was in his last year at school when the war began. He was killed. The two children who came after him are girls. The next boy is still in primary school. If he were old enough, I would have asked him to join the army, not minding the fact that my first son's head has already been sacrificed to the same war, for no person who breathes will say that he has no part in this war. But let me add this:- If this war has reached the stage when a man of my age is given a rifle by force and sent to the war front, then the time has come for you to blow the whistle and end the war. That is all I want to say!"

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult idioms?
- (e) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (f) difficult proverbs?
- (g) type of questioning method used?

Questions

1. The narrator is a
 - (a) farmer.
 - (b) tapper.
 - (c) wanderer.
 - (d) copper.
 - (e) friend of the soldiers.

2. **The soldiers had come to**
- (a) visit the man.
 - (b) drink his palm wine.
 - (c) tell him about the war.
 - (d) force him into the army.
 - (e) warn him about the enemies.
3. **The army was short of personnel because the soldiers**
- (a) were looking for new recruits.
 - (b) had lost the war.
 - (c) had suffered heavy losses.
 - (d) could not find people willing to sign on.
 - (e) had to recruit twenty men that day.
4. **The man would have sent his boy in the primary school to the army to show that**
- (a) he supported the war effort.
 - (b) he wasn't afraid to fight.
 - (c) the war concerned everybody alive.
 - (d) the war could still be won.
 - (e) his first son's death meant nothing to him.
5. **From the man's concluding statement, you can infer that**
- (a) the war had to be brought to an end.
 - (b) old men should not fight.
 - (c) whistles should be blown.
 - (d) only young men should fight.
 - (e) war is immoral.

(c) **Lexical Items:** Certain lexical items also make it difficult for candidates to understand a passage. Lexis means individual words that are used in a discourse. If there are certain words that are difficult, strange, long or unfamiliar, it is likely that, at the end of reading the passage, it will not have been understood. More dangerous is the fact that, if there are such words that

are strange, answers to certain questions can be attached to them, for example, 1998 (UME) passage 1.

Model Question 2

Those who have visited the city of Jos in Nigeria attest to its uniqueness. The first striking thing to notice perhaps is the benevolence of the climate. It will be no exaggeration to say that in no other Nigerian city does one feel so much at peace, so relaxed, with the climate as in Jos. When people say that Jos is cold, the remark is always a compliment, topographically symbolized by the surrounding rocky hills which adorn the horizon from every angle of the city. These hills remind you of castles, except that whereas castles are man-made, the hills of Jos are natural edifices in which the master mason who had delicately laid those stones one upon another is no other than God Himself. The sun of Jos shines without malice, and even in February and March, when it is scorchingly hot in most parts of Nigeria, the heat of Jos dances caressingly on the surface of the skin, as if afraid of hurting the organs beneath. It is as if from above, a soft protective layer of blanket intercedes between the heat of the sun and the inhabitants of the city.

Compared to what obtains in most other Nigerian cities, the inhabitants of Jos are openly warm. They are relaxed, and there is the absence of that suffocating feeling, with which a place like Lagos is associated, of a people madly rushing to their graves. The groceries operating at all nooks and crannies of the city give the impression of a great abundance of a variety of food items. It is almost as if some unseen hands are responsible for the presence of these varieties of edible items. The truth of course is that, in Jos, people – civil servants, farmers and traders – are socially well-disposed to the influx of new settlers and novel ideas, and this ensures an apparent high degree of self-sufficiency. You may be hungry in Jos, but you need not be angry.

If other parts of Nigeria had been like Jos, surely the colonialists would never have left the country without a good fight. Many monuments abound in the city which tell tales of the whiteman's love for this city of solid minerals.

In this passage, there are many difficult words – can you identify them and find their meanings?

Dealing with difficult words

The best ways of dealing with difficult words are the following:

(i) Contextualisation and environment

Each word should be related to the totality of the message of the passage. For example, the meaning of **goat**, **bank**, **bridge**, **philosophy**, **discipline** etc., would be different in their different contexts. For example:

- a. I keep my money in **bank**.
- b. When we got to the River Niger, we stood at the **bank**.

Bank is a polysemous word – a word that has many meanings/readings.

(ii) The Word Formation Approach

The second approach to difficult words is that you can use the principles of word formation to arrive at the answer to a difficult or long word. Word formation principles will enable you arrive at the meaning of a word such as UNFRIENDLINESS.

To begin analysis, ask, what is the root/base – that is, from which small word is the whole **unfriendliness** formed? It is **friend**. So, **un** is a prefix. Whatsoever comes after base word is a **suffix**, so, **liness** is the suffix. Note that almost every prefix has its meaning, e.g **un** means **not**, so, you can relate **not** to friend and arrive at your answer. You can treat long words this way.

It must, however, be said categorically that, not all words will yield themselves to the principle of word formation. For example, 'exaggeration' cannot yield to word formation analysis especially

because it has no prefix. Etymology – the study of the origin of words and their meanings – is what can help here.

More importantly, be very close to your dictionary, although, the dictionary should not be regarded as the final authority on the meaning of words. The context is the most reliable way of determining the meaning of words that do not yield themselves to word formation analysis.

*Please read more about this from A to Z (Lexis and Structure) section entitled: **Word Factory** – in this book.

(d) **Extra-grammatical Items:** Another set of items which authors and writers often adopt in writing is the extra-grammatical. These items include those phrases, clauses or expressions that cannot be easily understood because of their hidden meaning. They include the following:

(i) **Idiomatic Expressions**

As you know, expressions of this sort have hidden meanings. So, it is advisable for users of language to learn them in their hundreds. **A storm in the teacup, a bee in the bonnet, as the crow flies, forlorn hope, shed crocodile tears** and so on are examples of idioms. You will find a treatise on idiomatic expressions and how to analyse them in the Lexis and Structure section of this book.

(ii) **Figures of Speech**

Figures of speech are usually and frequently used to add colour to what is written but, often times, they become a problem for the reader. Major figures of speech used include: simile, metaphor, personification, irony, paralipsis.

Of all, metaphor and paralipsis are the most frequently used and are more difficult to comprehend than the others, in comprehension situation.

A metaphor is a word or phrase used when comparing something to another in a sharp way. An inscription on a bus reads: "Jesus – the Rock of Ages".

Paralipsis, on the other hand, is saying something as if it were not said. For example, a boy who has consistently failed his examination meets his father and makes this emotional plea:

Dad, even if you cannot buy me fashionable shirts and trousers; even if my toes peep out of my nine-year old tennis – and you cannot replace them; please pay my re-enrolment fees. I am not asking to be given three square meals a day as my friends are given by their parents and I'm not craving for pocket money which my friends' parents give them. All I'm saying is, please help with my re-enrolment fee.

You can see how many issues are raised by this boy who pretends to be bothered only by re-enrolment fees.

Obviously, he has succeeded in dragging his father's attention to the other issues where he likes to be helped: he likes to buy another pair of shoes; he wants pocket money; he wants fashionable outfits etc. but just says all these in a way to suggest that he does not attach much importance to them, although they are his priorities. This is paralipsis.

(iii) **Proverbs**

Although proverbs are not commonly used in English sentences, chances still remain, that an adapted passage (of your examination) may contain some proverbs, especially if the adapted passage is written by an author such as Chinua Achebe who uses proverbs in his work frequently. It is important that where these proverbs appear, they are well understood in relation to the subject of discussion.

Model Question 1

"You all know how friendly we are with Okperi. Do you think that any Umuaro man who goes to prison there will come back alive? But that apart, do you forget that this is the moon of planting? Do you want to grow this year's crops in the prison house in a land where your fathers owe a cow? I speak as your elder brother. I have travelled in Olu and I have travelled in Igbo, and I can tell you that there is no escape from the white man. He has come. When suffering knocks at your door and you say there is no seat left for him, he tells you not to worry because he has brought his own stool. The white man is like that. Before any of you here was old enough to tie a cloth between the legs, I saw with my own eyes what the white man did to Abame. Then I knew there was no escape. As daylight chases away darkness so will the white man drive away all our customs. I know that as I say it now it passes by your ears, but it will happen. The white man has power which comes from the true God and it burns like fire. This is the God about whom we preach every eighth day"

Unachukwu's opponents were now shouting that this was a meeting of an age group, that they had not assembled to join with him in chewing the seed of foolishness which they called their new religion.

"We are talking about the white man's road," said a voice above the others.

"Yes, we are talking about the white man's road. But when the roof and walls of a house fall in, the ceiling is not left standing. The white man, the new religion, the soldiers, the new road - they are all part of the same thing. The white man has a gun, a machet, a bow and carries fire in his mouth. He does not fight with one weapon alone."

(1)

(a)

(b)

The dominant subject of this passage is the

White man's road.

New religion.

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- (c) White man's influence.
- (d) White man's weapons.

(2) **According to the passage, the people of Umuaro and Okperi**

- (a) are friends.
- (b) are only acquaintances.
- (c) are no friends.
- (d) can never be enemies.

(3) **There is no escape from the white man in the passage means that the**

- (a) white man will send the people to prison.
- (b) white man can kill all the people with his gun.
- (c) people are only trying to run away from the white man.
- (d) people must accept the white man.

(4) **Passes by your ears in the passage means**

- (a) piercing through your ears.
- (b) listening eagerly.
- (c) making no impression.
- (d) accepting as the truth.

(5) **Unachukwu's speech in this passage shows that he**

- (a) is a coward.
- (b) wants his people to suffer.
- (c) loves the white man.
- (d) is wise with experience.

(iv) **Phrasal Verbs**

Phrasal verbs are statements formed by combining verbs or adverbial particles with prepositions. Examples are fall out, fall through, fall about, fall on, fall over, fall in, fall down, lie down, line up, lie against, fill in, fill up, and so on. The meanings of these expressions cannot be easily arrived at unless one learns them. **Extra-grammatical items:**

Phrasal Verbs section treats the intricacies of phrasal verbs and hundreds of phrasal verbs have been explained, exemplified and thoroughly discussed – with hundreds of examples in the Lexis and Structure section of this book.

Axioms/maxims/truisms

These are three of a kind. An example of what they are is **early to bed, early to rise; makes a man healthy, wealthy and wise/ health is wealth.**

In all, reasons have been shown why you need to understand all these expressions that cannot be easily understood. You are therefore advised to be familiar with the various expressions.

In summary, the first theory for analysing passages which is the chemistry theory, provides that the candidate should consider all the components that make up the passages and understand each of them perfectly. Again, they are the following: **Subject Matter, Theme, Lexical items** (difficult words), **Extra-grammatical items** under which are: **Idioms, figures of speech, proverbs, phrasal verbs, axioms, maxims and truisms.** This is the chemistry theory approach to the understanding of a comprehension passage.

2. The Psychoanalytic Theory

A second method of analyzing a comprehension passage is called the psychoanalytic theory. As the name suggests, the theory provides that all cogent points and facts of the passage must be collected and considered together to determine what is being talked about. Not everything that the author intends to say will be written but if the reader considers point numbers one and two and three together, it will be discovered that more facts could surface. For example, Joe is the oldest of three friends and Jack is the youngest. Tim is the third friend.

From these facts given, a further fact can be deduced:

- (i) **If Joe is ten years old and**
- (ii) **Jack is five years old, therefore**
- (iii) **Tim is between six and nine years old.**

But note that this third fact is not given in the statement; it is psychoanalysis that enables us to arrive at the conclusion.

It should be noted very well that, using psychoanalysis does not imply that the reader should think of facts that are not products of the already existing facts of the passage. This means, it is dangerous using one's intuition, sentiments or personal experience or opinion to analyse instead of relying on only facts already supplied in the passage for the process of psychoanalysis. Consider the example of the UME 1981 passage.

Model Question 1

It was on a Sunday afternoon that I saw the lorry standing in front of the post office. I had seen it long before my brother saw it, but it was he who said to me, "Don't you think it odd that the post office should be open this afternoon?" "What do you think is happening? Come round the corner, out of sight, and let's watch," I answered. My brother Michael was younger than me, so I kept him behind me, and peering round the corner told him what I saw. "There are four men coming out, carrying a very heavy iron box." "Oh!" I exclaimed, "It's a safe." "I think they're burglars," said my brother, who was full of suspicion. "One of them has fallen over," I said; "the safe is too heavy for them." "You go and fetch the police," said my brother, "and I'll stay here and watch." "No, you go and get them," I replied, because I wanted to see what was going to happen. My brother ran off and then, suddenly, a man came running out of the post office, shouting, "Hurry! Hurry! Hurry! Get it on the lorry!" He joined the first four and they managed to get the safe up on the back of the lorry. When they had done this, the man who had shouted got into the driver's seat, but the lorry would not start. Just then my brother came back with three policemen. To cut a long story short,

the men were all arrested and my brother and I had to go and give evidence before a magistrate. The men went to prison, of course, in the end, but you should have seen the face of the leader – it was contorted with rage – when he learned that the safe they had managed to steal was empty, and all the money was in the bank.

Fill in the following information:

What is/are the:

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult idioms?
- (e) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (f) difficult proverbs?

Go ahead and answer the following questions:

1. **The brothers thought it was odd for the post office to be open because**

- (a) nobody works on Sundays.
- (b) people should be in church.
- (c) post offices should open only five days in the week.
- (d) they were ignorant.
- (e) that was probably the second time they had seen it open on a Sunday.

2. **The narrator kept his younger behind him because**

- (a) big brothers must protect their younger ones.
- (b) he wanted to relay all that was happening to him.
- (c) his brother was too short for his liking.
- (d) younger brothers are not easily frightened.
- (e) he was very brave.

3. **The brothers decided to call the police because**

- (a) they thought they were burglars.
- (b) policemen are required on such occasions.

- (c) calling the policemen was the only thing they could have done.
- (d) they were cowardly.
- (e) they would have wished to give evidence in court.

4. **The robbers could not escape because**

- (a) the safe was too heavy.
- (b) they were sinners who deserved punishment.
- (c) the engine of their lorry failed.
- (d) they were not smart enough.
- (e) nemesis wanted to catch up with them.

5. **The leader of the robbers was angry because**

- (a) his gang was arrested.
- (b) the safe was empty.
- (c) they were all going to prison.
- (d) spending their loot would be impossible.
- (e) he was an irascible man.

Note: It is not stated in the passage why "the brothers thought it was odd for the post office to be open". Now use psychoanalysis to get further facts which will enable you answer questions 1, 2, 3 and 4 which cannot be arrived at without psychoanalysis because the points are not written word-for-word in the passage.

3. **The Cause-and-Effect Theory**

It is obvious that, in a passage, one event follows another. It is not compulsory that the author put the events in sequential order but it remains imperative for the reader to plot or arrange the events in the order in which they happened (as described in the passage). One major headache of candidates is how to determine what is responsible for what; in other words, most readers cannot authoritatively ascribe the correct cause of something to an event. *Non-cause, pro-cause, propter ergo hoc* (translation: giving a wrong cause to an event) is a major problem. It has to do with the principle of logical reasoning.

It is quite illogical for anyone to insist that the failure of the candidate (in the statement below) is a result of his travelling to Lagos.

"Whenever I travel to Lagos, and come back to school to sit for my examinations, I usually fail them."

There is no direct link between travelling on the one hand and failure or success on the other. Perhaps, if he had said that he had been consistently travelling out of the school and unable to do any academic work during the session and that whenever he wrote his papers after such prolonged absence from school, he was sure to fail, that would have been more logical.

There is a difference: Visiting Lagos once does not have any direct link with one's failure but persistent, peripatetic oscillations and travelling – and absence from classes can bring failure. So, watch out; do not ascribe a wrong cause to an event; trace event to its ROOT cause e.g UME 1982 passage C.

Model Question 1

I was on top of one of my palm trees yesterday, tapping the tree and collecting the wine for the morning, when I saw two soldiers at the foot of the tree. They made signs at me, so I concluded that they wanted my palm wine. On descending from the tree, I gave them the wine to sample, as it is customary. Not only did they drain all the wine in the calabash, but they also said they had come to conscript me into the army. I asked them whether they wanted me or somebody else, and they said they had come for me. I asked them whether an enemy sent them or they came on their own. To cut it short, they said I was wasting their time as they had to catch twenty men that day. Only a foolish man willingly disobeys armed soldiers. I told them I had something very important to say.

Say it, then, one of them cut in impatiently, looking at his watch. It was approaching midday, by which time it was considered unsafe to drive around in a car for fear of enemy planes which had learnt to strafe individual vehicles on the highway.

"Yes, what I want to say is simple," I said. "My first son, the boy who should have succeeded me when I died, joined the army

voluntarily and with my full backing. He was a brilliant boy, always first in his class. He was in his last year at school when the war began. He was killed. The two children who came after him are girls. The next boy is still in primary school. If he were old enough, I would have asked him to join the army, not minding the fact that my first son's head had already been sacrificed to the same war. For no person who breathes will say that he has no part in this war.

But let me add this: - If this war has reached the stage when a man of my age is given a rifle by force and sent to the war front, then the time has come for you to blow the whistle and end the war. That is all I want to say!"

1. **The narrator is a**

- (a) farmer.
- (b) tapper.
- (c) wanderer.
- (d) copper.
- (e) friend of the soldiers.

2. **The soldiers had come to**

- (a) visit the man.
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- (c) tell him about the war.
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- (a) he supported the war effort.
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- (c) the war concerned everybody alive.
- (d) the war could still be won.
- (e) his first sons' death meant nothing to him.

5. **From the man's concluding statement you can infer that**

- (a) the war had to be brought to an end.
- (b) old men should not fight.
- (c) whistles should be blown.
- (d) only young men should fight.
- (e) war is immoral.

Now, use the cause and effect theory to answer question 3.

By the time these three theories are applied, namely:

The Chemistry theory (for getting to understand the passage)

The Psychoanalytic theory (for creation of more relevant facts)

The Cause-and-effect theory (for determining the cause of an event), the candidate will have been guaranteed full mastery of the

whole passage, ready to answer the questions. This means that

when you have a passage, before you consider the different

components, use logic to get to the complete facts (psychoanalysis)

and, finally think about the appropriate causes of events described.

WHY CANDIDATES CHOOSE WRONG ANSWERS

In objective tests – under comprehension, some options usually resemble one another although, if well perused, it would be discovered that there is often a wide margin of difference between options. The major reasons for the wrong choice of options usually chosen by candidates include the following:

(i) **Misinterpretation of Question**

It is logical that, once a question is not well understood, the correct answer will not be arrived at. A lot of candidates are often in so much of a hurry or are psychologically unsettled that they do not bother to understand the exact demands of the question.

It is therefore imperative that a candidate should not rush but strive to understand what the question means – e.g. UME 1978 Question 20. In your own words, state what question 20 means and then, answer the question with care. It is a PERIPHRASTIC question.

Model Question 2

These two factors, the altitude and the weather; tend separately and together to defeat the climber. The height weakens, slows him down; it forces him to spend days and nights in the course of his assault on the summit; the weather, besides adding to the demands of his energy and moral fortitude, conspires to deny him the time he needs to complete his mission. Whereas in lower mountains and on easy ground, the weather may be no more than a handicap, in the high Himalayas it is decisive, regardless of terrain.

The deduction to be drawn from these two factors was clear enough. We must either so fortify ourselves that we could continue, without detriment, to live and have our being above the limit of natural acclimatization, or, better still, we must solve the problem of speed. It was desirable, in fact, that we should meet both these requirements and thus give to those chosen to attempt the summit and to their supporting teams some measure of insurance against the vagaries

of the weather, for safety in mountain climbing is as much a matter of swiftness as of sureness of foot. Either or both could be achieved only by the administration of oxygen in sufficient quantities to make up for the deficiency in the air, and for the duration of the upward journey above the limit of successful acclimatization.

1. **The author believes that to overcome the problems of altitude and weather, the climber needs mainly**

- (a) courage and speed.
- (b) energy and moral fortitude.
- (c) sufficient quantities of oxygen.
- (d) swiftness and sureness of foot.
- (e) quick acclimatization.

2. **conspires means**

- (a) ruins.
- (b) makes secret plans.
- (c) takes a wicked action.
- (d) combines.
- (e) aggravates.

3. **regardless of terrain means**

- (a) ever on easy ground.
- (b) despite the nature of the ground.
- (c) because of steeper gradients.
- (d) ignoring the inhospitality of the mountainside.
- (e) without considering the handicap.

4. **to live and have our being above the limit of natural acclimatization means**

- (a) to be protected from the effects of the weather.
- (b) to expect no protection from the bad weather.
- (c) to survive under unnatural weather conditions.
- (d) limit our natural desires to get acclimatized to the weather.
- (e) none of the above.

5. Which ONE of the following was NOT a reason for using oxygen?

- (a) It gave them psychological encouragement.
- (b) It fortified them to live above the limit of natural acclimatization.
- (c) It protected them against the unexpected changes of the weather.
- (d) It quickened their journey to the summit.
- (e) It helped them to survive the worst effects of the weather.

Do you notice that the question is merry-go-round; not straight or direct?

(ii) **Use of Sentiments**

Sentiments are personal ideas or personal opinions concerning a particular thing. Many passages are set and questions on them usually tempt the candidate to use his or her idea of the subject matter, to answer the question now. On no account should a candidate go outside the provision of the passage to look for answers; you cannot use your own idea just because what is being described in the passage happened to you before. Rely ONLY on what the passage states, even if it is different from your own experience. Consider 1982, passage V and then answer questions 22 and 23.

Model Question 3

Professor Ikin emerged from the charm incident a changed man. During the preceding months when his wife had talked persistently about Dr Okoro and his American friends, he had paid little heed to her. He assumed that nagging was her way of life. Dr Okoro did not constitute a threat to him; they were not in the same department so they could not be competing for the headship of the department. Even if they taught the same subject, Okoro could surely not be deemed to be a rival to him. He was an Associate Professor while Okoro had only just become a Lecturer Grade II. If he had yielded to his father's pressure to marry early he might have

produced a child as old as Dr Okoro. Two members of the Provisional Council had intentionally dropped broad hints that he was lined up to take over from Dr Wilson as Vice Chancellor. He did not therefore need to take any more notice of Dr Okoro's attitude towards him than a cow take notice of a fly perching on its back.

It was true Dr Okoro got on well with the Americans who happened to be at the helm of the affairs at Songhai. But what could they do for him? At best, in the teeth of strong opposition from all quarters, they could make him a Senior Lecturer. Even that would require the approval of the Provisional Council, and Okoro should not take for granted that half the members would not accept him as a child born today who would attain full maturity tomorrow. Professor Ikin knew what displeased the Americans about him - it was his lack of a Ph.D., but he hoped that over the years they would learn to judge a man by what he produces rather than by the degrees he has accumulated. If they did not, it was just too bad because only an earthquake could move him away from Songhai at such a crucial stage of its development.

1. **From this passage, it is clear that Professor Ikin**

- (a) loves his wife very dearly.
- (b) doesn't value what his wife says.
- (c) hates his wife.
- (d) does not trust his wife.
- (e) is not a serious man.

2. **Dr Okoro cannot be seen as a threat to Professor Ikin because**

- (a) he is very junior to Professor Ikin in the university hierarchy.
- (b) a cow does not take notice of a fly perching on its back.
- (c) Professor Ikin is old enough to be Dr Okoro's father.
- (d) a Doctor is inferior to a Professor.
- (e) they do not teach the same subject.

3. **Professor Ikin is hopeful of advancement because**

- (a) he is much older than Dr Okoro.
- (b) Dr Wilson is retiring.

- (c) he is influential in the Provisional Council.
- (d) he received prior information of his possible appointment as Vice-Chancellor.
- (e) he is a Professor.

4. **Despite the fact that the Americans like Dr Okoro, he may not be made a Senior Lecturer because**

- (a) the Americans are not influential.
- (b) Professor Ikin is opposed to him.
- (c) there will be opposition from all quarters.
- (d) he would be judged by his qualifications.
- (e) he may be considered inexperienced.

5. **The Americans are displeased with Professor Ikin because**

- (a) he hates Dr Okoro.
- (b) he does not like his wife.
- (c) they see him as not sufficiently, academically qualified.
- (d) they only like people who worship them.
- (e) they are at the helm of affairs at Songhai.

(iii) **Extra-grammatical Items Becloud Meaning**

We have mentioned certain extra-grammatical items—idioms, axioms, maxims, proverbs, phrasal verbs and figures of speech — which make passages difficult. When a lot of these are used in the passage, there is a great tendency that a candidate who is not very familiar with these extra-structural items will not understand. Find every such item out of the passage, determine its meaning and relate its message to the totality of the passage.

(iv) **Technical Words**

Some passages deliberately include some words which have no clear-cut meaning concerning what is discussed in the passage. For example, if a passage reads:

“Perhaps they will pass.”

This means (i) they may pass and
(ii) they may fail.

There is no clear-cut meaning. Let us imagine that a question asks: What, according to the passage, will be the fate of the students described in the passage?

- (a) Success is awaiting them.
- (b) They are bound to fail.
- (c) Their fate is undecided.
- (d) If they work hard, they will pass.

Answer (c): This is because of the weight of **perhaps**. (d) is not correct because, we are not told that hard work can make them pass in the passage and we do not have to imply it, just because we know that hard work leads to success. Using sentiment or personal experience is quite out of the way.

Other technical words that must be handled with care are: **only, sometimes, partially, seldom, probably, hopefully almost, reasonably, usually, as against, always, virtually, etc.** For example:

- He **seldom** appears in public. (not **always**)
- They **almost** collapsed. (not **really**)
- We **usually** weep when mourning. (not **always**)
- He is **probably** happy. (not **sure**)
- She **virtually** finished the food. (not **really**)

See UME, 1982 paragraphs 1 & 2 of passage 1.

Note question 2. Attempt to answer it.

Model Question 4

Olumba removed a small black amulet from his neck and substituted a bigger one. The former was for general protection at home, the latter for protection and luck whilst travelling. Ready at last he picked up his machete and headed for the chief's house with Ikechi behind him.

Olumba walked ahead looking upwards as usual. Just what he was searching for in the sky Ikechi couldn't tell. Perhaps, his

shortness accounted for this habit since he often had to look up into the faces of his taller companions. What he lacked in height he made up in solid muscle and he looked strong. His wrestling pseudonym was Agadaga, a name which meant nothing but which somehow conveyed an impression of strength.

Eze Diali, the chief, sat at one end of his reception hall ringed by the village elders whom he had called to a meeting. The rest of the hall was filled with much younger men.

"People of Chiolu," the chief began, "I have learnt that poachers from Aliakoro will be at the Great Ponds tonight. There is no doubt that they will try to steal from the Pond of Wagaba which as you know is rich in fish. Our plan tonight is to bring one or more of these thieves home alive and ask for very large ransoms. This line of action will have two effects. Firstly, it will prove our charges of poaching against the people of Aliakoro, and secondly, the payment of very large ransoms would be a deterrent. We need seven men for this venture. I call for volunteers."

"Who will head this party?" the chief asked, looking round. Chituru, one of the elders, said: "Eze Diali, let us not waste time. Olumba is the man for the job. We all know that he had led many exploits like this one."

"We still need six men," Eze Diali said. Eager youths came surging forward. Their well-formed muscles rippled as they elbowed one another. It was difficult to choose.

"I suggest Olumba should choose his men. He knows the boys very well and his judgement should be reliable." It was Wezume, another village elder, who spoke.

1. **Olumba wore amulets because he**
- (a) was superstitious.
 - (b) was a strong and fearless fighter.
 - (c) wanted to please his wife.
 - (d) wanted to instill fear in Eze.
 - (e) believed in the power of protection.

Olumba looked upwards because

- 2.
- (a) he was searching for something in the sky.
 - (b) this was his usual practice.
 - (c) he was short and often had to look up.
 - (d) he lacked height.
 - (e) his wrestling pseudonym was Agadaga.

Poaching means

- 3.
- (a) stealing.
 - (b) cracking eggs.
 - (c) fishing.
 - (d) demanding ransoms from Aliakoro.
 - (e) deterring thieves.

The chief called the meeting because

- 4.
- (a) he wanted volunteers to go to Aliakoro.
 - (b) he wanted to announce the fact that there would definitely be poachers from Chiolu at the Great Ponds that night.
 - (c) he wanted to ask for very large ransoms because the people of Chiolu needed money for fishing.
 - (d) the elders had devised a plan to prevent the poaching.
 - (e) seven men were needed to bring seven thieves home.

Why was Olumba chosen?

- 5.
- (a) in order not to waste time.
 - (b) because his nickname conveyed an impression of strength.
 - (c) his amulets for luck were stronger than anyone else's in the village.
 - (d) he had caught thieves alive before.
 - (e) The passage doesn't say.

QUESTIONING METHODS

Almost all examination bodies are consistent in their method of asking comprehension passage questions. It means that, we can predict the questions that will come out in the next examination. Yes, if we do not know the questions word-for-word, the types of questions to be featured are certainly known. And with consistent practice, you are guaranteed to arrive at correct answers throughout.

Question formulators use several methods to set comprehension passage questions. A candidate who does not know the type of questioning method used in the question before him or her is comparable to a traveller, travelling northwards by taking a southward direction but the one who could identify the method used in framing the question before him or her is definitely close on the heels of the question moulder.

The methods are the following:

1. **Thematic questions**

Thematic questions – or to use its other name, **suitability questions** will ask the candidate to identify or **choose an option which best suits the passage.**

It may also ask you to **suggest a suitable title for the passage.** It does not end there. A suitability question will ask you – **what is the tone or mood of the speaker or writer** – or **what is the theme** of the passage. It may also ask you to **suggest the basic aim of the passage.**

Approach: When you are asked to find a suitable title for a passage, you must have first found out what the subject matter is, the theme and lessons which the passage intends to teach. An aspect of a large discourse in a passage cannot be taken to form the topic. You must find a title that has bearing with everything discussed in the passage. Still under suitability, if you are asked about the tone, mood and theme, you should be careful.

Mood means the condition of one's mind at a time an action is performed. For example, if someone cries, do you think he or she is in a good frame of mind? No. So, the mood is **gloomy, moody, sad, unhappy, mourning, equanimous, phlegmatic**. But suppose someone suddenly shouts: "Hurray – I've got it!" In what mood is that person? **Happy, vivacious, lively, pleased, contented, elated**, etc. So, mood means the condition of the mind. **Tone** means the **weight of language** used in a discourse.

It is one's mood that leads to the tone, that is, one's language depends on one's mood. So, **tone** means the language used in expressing your mood (feelings). You can have the following types of tone:

Critical tone: This has to do with language that criticizes or condemns something.

Satirical tone: This is a tone that does not condemn something straight away but dramatizes it, so that people can see that it is bad and condemn it. 1987 UME passage 1, question 1 is an excellent example.

PASSAGE 1

There are one or two things this country can teach others, one of which is the art of writing obituaries. One suspects that the reason why some of our newspapers still manage to break even is because of the great amount of revenue they derive from obituaries. It is not unusual for about one quarter of the volume of an average daily to be constituted of obituaries and In memoriam alone. One possible explanation for this, it has been argued, is that Nigerians value their dead greatly. And there is a saying among us that you do not say evil things against the dead. This is obviously the philosophy behind the large dose of encomiums with which our dead are bestowed.

From the evidences of these obituaries and In memoriam, every dead Nigerian must have been something of a saint while alive. This would explain why the death of most Nigerians is attributed to the evil machinations of the wicked. Only very few people in our country die natural death, and even when they do, the obituaries etc always give the impression that such deaths constitute the saddest loss to befall the deceased's family. And that is why writers of these obituaries and their allied advertisements are experts on 'mortuary stylistics'. This "mortuary stylistics", the study in the art of eulogizing the dead and making their loss sound so heart breaking, is one of the commodities we can export to other countries.

Note: Question 1 is a **thematic** question. Answer it now.

1. **The tone of this passage is**
 - a. angry.
 - b. satirical.
 - c. non-committal.
 - d. pleasant.
2. **Mortuary stylistics as used in the passage refers to the**
 - a. art of writing obituaries.
 - b. text of obituaries.
 - c. study of obituaries.
 - d. art of eulogizing the dead.
3. **"One suspects that the reason why some of our newspapers still manage to break even ..." suggests that some Nigerian newspapers.**
 - a. would be running at a loss but for obituaries.
 - b. are patronised only because they specialise in obituaries.
 - c. derive all their revenue from obituaries.
 - d. invest huge revenue in obituaries.
4. **Obituaries are very popular in Nigeria because**
 - a. evil things are not said against the dead.
 - b. every dead Nigerian must have lived a saintly life.
 - c. only very few Nigerians die natural deaths.

Nigerians value their dead greatly.

d. Which of the following can be deduced from the passage?

5. The writer believes that most Nigerians do not die natural deaths.
- a. Obituaries insinuate that most Nigerians do not die natural deaths.
- b. The writer is convinced that every death in Nigeria is a big blow to the bereaved.
- c. The writer suspects that every death in Nigeria is a big blow to the bereaved.
- d.

For further example, if a cartoonist draws a policeman who is secretly receiving 20 naira from a commercial bus driver as bribe, that cartoon is not trying to praise that policeman but to let people see how he operates so that they can condemn him. That is **Satire**.

There is also the tone of **approval** or **disapproval** (of what the writer discusses) and the tone of **condemnation**. The tone of condemnation is like the critical tone.

There is the **non-committal** tone. This tone means that, concerning what is being discussed, the writer does not take any side – condemn or praise. He only sees all sides as equal, No final, clear judgement is given. **Sermonizing tone** means preaching or teaching. **Analytical tone** means explanatory etc. See 1988 UME question, practise 1988 question 10 as a suitability, topic-making question.

Model Question 2

To listen properly is a hard job, and probably one of the toughest skills in the art of communication. Good listening has nothing to do with proper functioning of one's auditory organs, which is assumed to be inevitable. Good listening, in the sense we are interested in, is not a biological factor, but a psychological one. Your auditory organs are not in order when actually you cannot use them creatively. Creative listening implies your being efficient in the

art of concentration; in other words, while you are concentrating to hear all that is being said, you are also thinking fast, digesting what is being said, allowing your mental faculties and your memory to accept that which you understand, and to reject that which you do not understand, sorting out what you do not understand and storing them somewhere in your brain for future discussion, and, all at the same time, rationalizing what you hear, accepting that which you find rational and rejecting that which you do not find rational.

After you must have listened creatively to what you have been told, then you can respond if the need arises. It is quite proper that you respond, because the process of response enhances the art of communication. But your response ought to be only a necessary response, a response that will improve your understanding. This response should involve your mentioning some of those things you have been told but which you do not understand, or politely questioning the rationality of some of the speaker's argument. But your response must be constructive; must enhance the communicative worth. It should not be an unnecessary argument, or an opportunity for you to express dissatisfaction or disaffection. The ability to listen properly aids communication and understanding.

1. **The passage says that**

- a. there are many skills of communication of which listening is one.
- b. the art of listening is the toughest of all communication skills.
- c. good listening depends on perfect functioning of the auditory organs.
- d. good listening needs formal training.

2. **Creative listening involves all the following EXCEPT**

- a. efficient concentration.
- b. making sure that what the speaker is saying is audible.
- c. that the listener must be able to think fast.
- d. that there must be a co-ordination of all the objective faculties.

Creative listening implies all EXCEPT

- 3. a critical enterprise.
- a. an uncompromising rejection of the speaker's argument.
- b. some argument with the speaker.
- c. a great deal of discipline.
- d.

The tone of the passage is

- 4. sermonizing.
- a. pleading.
- b. analytical.
- c. argumentative.
- d.

A most suitable title for the passage is

- 5. communication skills.
- a. how to listen attentively.
- b. listening in communication.
- c. listening argument and understanding.
- d.

Note: Questions 4 & 5 are **thematic, suitability questions**. It will be up to you to determine the type of tone and mood you are dealing with. So, you should know the difference between the following moods: **anger, happiness or joy, enthusiasm** (interest) **indifference**, (that is, the writer is not bothered by what he discusses); mood of **hope, despair** (loss of hope) **regret, optimism** – (positive hope for the future) and **pessimism** (negative hope for the future).

2. **Authorial Questions**

This type of question will start with **according to the author/ according to the passage/ the writer says that / in the writer's view** etc. The question may also be asked in a way that you will be tempted to use your own ideas instead of the passage writer's.

Approach: Please, whenever a question is framed this way, the trick is to make you fall by using your own idea. Do not use any consideration apart from what you are given in the passage or what the writer says. If you use your ideas, be sure that your answer is

wrong. Even, if the option which is the same as the writer's idea is against your personal principle, choose it. A passage discusses the use of cocaine. The writer praises cocaine as good. The question comes: According to the passage, (a) cocaine medication is good (b) cocaine medication is bad. We know it is bad but, according to the writer, a is correct.

3. Refutational questions

Refute means "to say that something is not true". So, a refutational question seems to be asking you to remove the one (out of five or so options) that is not true, according to the passage. Only four (the remaining options) are right.

Approach: To be able to refute, you must consider all the options alongside information available in the passage. In this type of question, the passage can use a method to confuse the candidate. That method is **lexical or syntactic distortion**.

Lexical distortion is a deliberate confusion at word level. When the options are set out, one will look very much like what you read in the passage but only one word will make it different from what the passage actually means. Only one word!

Syntactic distortion is a deliberate confusion at sentence level, when a sentence option which looks much like what is in the passage is changed – using more than one word in the sentence to effect a change. For example, a passage discusses Universities and the appearance of the entrance. The passage discusses the beautiful welcome that a University gate should give to a first-time visitor. Now which of the following is not true according to the passage: (a) The entrance to a Nigerian University should be attractive. (b) The entrance to a University should be attractive. Which one is not true?

It is **A**. In the passage, **Nigerlan** is not there, whereas, in the option (to confuse you), **Nigerlan** is added. Be careful and watch out clearly for any differences. This is an example of **lexical distortion**.

Model Question

Read the passage carefully and the questions that follow.

PASSAGE

As the stranger approached, Shola noticed that he was handsome and her excitement increased. It was of such a man she had dreamt. He had a fine, arrogant carriage, like a soldier or someone in authority. When he reached the end of the pier, he addressed them in a rich, deep voice that disturbed her as the voluptuous rising of the tide had done.

"You're Tunde Onu, I'm told," he said to her father.

"That's right," said her father.

"The bus conductor told me you take people to the Islands," the man continued. "I'd like to go there if you can take me."

Her father examined the man from head to foot, shrewdly measuring his capacity to pay. Then, he said:

"When are you thinking of going?"

"Right away."

"That's a different story, for my boatman is gone to Badagry and he won't be back before nightfall."

"Oh!" said the stranger. "That's too bad. You couldn't get someone else instead of him?"

"I would have to think hard," he said gloomily, "for it's not everyone would do for the job of going with me beyond the bay to the Islands at this time of the year."

Shola understood her father's manoeuvre and felt ashamed.

How would you describe Shola's father?

- (a) A greedy boatman.
- (b) An energetic but good-for-nothing man.
- (c) A loving father who wants to safeguard the interest of his daughter.
- (d) A talkative fool.

2.

Which of the following is NOT true of the passage?

- (a) Shola did not approve of her father's behaviour towards the stranger.
- (b) Shola's father could row the stranger to the Islands alone had he so wished.
- (c) Shola's father exaggerated the difficulties in order to raise his fee.
- (d) Shola had recently been disturbed by the tide.

3.

Which of the following is true of the stranger in the passage?

- (a) He was a proud and good looking man with a deep voice that annoyed Shola.
- (b) He was familiar with the people of the Islands.
- (c) He was a fine gentleman in need of help.
- (d) He was too proud to reciprocate Shola's love.

4.

Manoeuvre in the passage means

- (a) shrewdness.
- (b) cleverness.
- (c) stupidity.
- (d) strategy.

5.

Which of the following is true of the passage?

- (a) The stranger was in a bad mood.
 - (b) The stranger came by bus.
 - (c) Shola and her father were idle when the stranger came.
 - (d) Shola's father measured the stranger from head to foot.
- * Note that Shola's father did not measure the stranger but measured his capacity to pay.

4.

Evaluation questions

An evaluation question is the one which asks you about the character of an individual mentioned in a passage or asks you to describe an event or to judge a situation – good or bad, successful or failed etc.

Approach: To determine the character of an individual, do the following: (a) Consider what the individual says and how he or she says it, that is, the language, good English, pidgin or bad English. (b) Consider his actions – what he does. (c) Consider what other people in the passage say about him/her. When you do these you have done characterisation. You will have the correct answer.

Concerning events, if people died in the story, it is **tragic**. If there are jokes, light moods and fun, the event is **comic**. If the event has a mixture of both (above), it is **tragicomic**. If the event ends on a successful note (although at the beginning there were problems), you would say it was completely successful because, all is well that ends well.

Comment: Still using the last passage, answer questions 1 & 3. Use the three principles of characterization.

5. **Logical questions**

You cannot escape this type of question. It is the question that compels you to use the principles of logic. Logic is considering various facts to be able to arrive at a conclusion as judges do in law courts – if this is this and that is that, then, this should be this.

Approach: The approach to this question is that, you have to be careful not to rush to any conclusion until you have seriously considered some circumstances, e.g. someone has been reading novels, History, Geology and Geography textbooks; takes interest in science, knows about sports and photography, does some technical drawing and calculation and intends to study law at the university for four years. After his university education; that person will become (a) a lawyer (b) a judge (c) historian (d) learned person (e) author. Try the answer. **He will not be a lawyer but a learned person** because he has been reading other subjects in which he has interest. So, he will not become a lawyer but an all-rounder, sort of and, that is a “learned person”. Be careful. Consider facts before selecting your answer. Try UME of 1982 questions 13 and 15. Use logic.

Model Question

Dear John,

Many thanks for your letter. I was very glad to hear that you had done so well in your examinations. Let me send you my hearty congratulations. You certainly deserved this result as I know you worked very hard.

You asked how I have been spending the time since I took my examinations. I have been waiting so eagerly for the results that, I must admit, I have not done half the things I planned to do during this extended holiday.

However, I have been doing a lot of reading. There were so many different things I was interested in when I was at school and did not have the time to read about because they were not on the syllabus. I have read two books about geology, which is a fascinating subject. I hope to make a hobby of geology when I get to the University. It will make a change from the study of law, I have also read several novels, mostly modern ones by authors like Graham Greene, C.S. Forester and Somerset Maugham. How enjoyable it is to read a book for pleasure and not for an examination! I have not given a thought to law, and not read one book about the subject. I shall have four long years at the University to devote to it.

I have also been going once or twice a week to the National Boys' Club every Sunday afternoon.

I will certainly let you know my examination results as soon as I have them. I must say that I become less confident about the results each day. It was encouraging to hear that this was the case with you, and since you did so well perhaps there is still hope for me!

Yours sincerely,
Osman.

1. **John deserved to pass his examinations because**

- a. the examinations were easy.
- b. he was a brilliant student.
- c. he prepared very well for it.
- d. he was a lucky student.
- e. the examiner was very liberal.

2. **You will regard Osman during term as a student who reads**

- a. all types of books.
- b. always.
- c. all the subjects on the curriculum.
- d. much more than other students.
- e. only the books that are prescribed.

3. **Osman couldn't do most of what he had planned for the holidays because**

- a. he thought he would fail.
- b. he was afraid of failure.
- c. waiting for the results made him sick.
- d. his anxiety for the results of the examinations made other activities unattractive to him.
- e. he could not find anything else to do.

4. **From the passage, we can see that Osman intends to become**

- a. a very learned man.
- b. the cleverest man in his family.
- c. a lawyer.
- d. the chief magistrate of his district
- e. a writer of books.

5. **Osman became less confident of his results each day but that does not mean that**

- a. he will pass.
- b. he will fail.
- c. he is a coward.
- d. he is hopeless.
- e. he is lazy.

6. **Direct questions**

Direct questions appear to be the simplest type of questions. It is so direct that anybody could just supply an answer to it from the passage. The method used in framing direct questions resembles the method you were used to, in your primary school days. The question will start with an interrogative pronoun, such as what, where, when, why, who, which, how often etc. You will discover that the answer to any of these questions is there, ready in the passage.

Approach: To approach this type of question, you have to apply certain theories of evidence. These will be discussed later, under the title **THE THEORY OF EVIDENCE** in this book.

7. **Periphrastic questions**

Periphrastic questions are formed in a round-about, indirect way, e.g. 'Which one of the following is NOT untrue of the Igbo? (i.e. "Which one is true of the Igbo"?) Also: Which one of the following is not a reason given by the author for not attending the party (i.e. four of the five options are reasons given by the author for not attending; the fifth option is not one of the reasons – which one is not the reason?) So, which of these is not unimportant will become "Which of these is important".

Approach: If you find a question, as tricky as this, first attempt to get things right: dismantle the question; carefully understand, by reframing the question into a straight-forward question, the meaning of the question. Many a candidate has blamed himself/herself for being in much haste when dealing with this type of question. If you are not very careful, "which is not untrue" may be misinterpreted as

"which is untrue" by you. In whatever form a tricky question might come, please, try to understand it by analysing it.

8. Contextual questions

A contextual question is the one which asks for the meaning of a word as it is used in the passage. Most candidates usually give the dictionary meaning of words instead of looking at the meaning of the question in relation to the circumstances or situation or "context" of the word, e.g. "David has been fighting his friends for the past two weeks. He no more has a playmate because he is a goat."

Question: **Goat** means (a) a brave, fearless boy. (b) black boy. (c) a four legged, domestic animal. (d) an aggressive character. (e) a cold blooded animal.

Now, if we consider the context well, we will discover that (d) is correct although, **goat**, as a dictionary word, means among other things – a domestic animal. Get it straight now: the dictionary is not the final arbiter on the meaning of a word but the situation surrounding or the context in which a word is used is the impervious, oracular and authoritative arbiter of meaning.

Comment: Attempt the following questions: UME 1998 question 10, 1989 question 10, 1991 question 17.

Model Question

Population has at last made the grade and emerged as a world problem. Unfortunately, most of those who speak or write about it persist in thinking of it in terms of a race between human numbers and world resources, especially of food - a kind of competition between production and reproduction.

Certainly, the statistics churned out are important, revealing that indeed, there is a population explosion. But the real explosion is a twentieth century phenomenon, due primarily to the spectacular development in medicine and hygiene. This has drastically cut down death rates without any corresponding reduction in birth rates; death

control without birth control. World population, we are told, has more than doubled since 1900 and will certainly reach well over 5½ billion and possibly 7 billion by the magical year 2000.

The population has brought us up against a number of tough ecological facts. Man is at last pressing hard on his spatial environment - there is little leeway left for his colonization of new areas of the world's surface.

What are people for? Surely, people do not exist just to provide "bomb-fodder" for an atomic bonfire, or "religious-fodder" for rival religious sects, or "cannon-fodder" for rival national armies, or rival political parties, or even "consumer-fodder" for profit-making systems. It cannot be their aim just to eat, drink and be merry, and to hell with posterity, nor to live out their undernourished lives in some squalid Asian or African village.

Man's dominant aim must be to increase in quality - quality of human personality, of achievement, of inner experience, quality of life and of living in general. "Fulfillment" is probably the embracing word; more fulfillment, more satisfaction and less frustration for more homo sapiens. Man wants more varied and fuller achievement in the society as opposed to drabness and shrinkages. We want more knowledge and more interest as against ignorance and apathy. Then, would we know that the spatial environment is not as small as we think.

1. **The theme of the passage is**

- a. population explosion and development in medicine.
- b. man in a deprived world development in medicine and hygiene.
- c. development in medicine and hygiene.
- d. population and the need for qualitative development.

2. **Population explosion is as a result of**

- a. cut down in death rates and birth rates.
- b. lack of birth control and child welfare.
- c. development in environmental sanitation.

- d. imbalance between death control and birth control.
3. **According to the passage, population explosion has brought man up against the ecological facts of**
- a. man's inhumanity to man, hunger and deprivation.
 - b. pressing hard on the little available space.
 - c. little leeway of the man's colonization of people.
 - d. squalid African villages.
4. **According to the passage, the main purpose of human existence is**
- a. for procreation.
 - b. to provide cannon-fodder.
 - c. to live perpetually in penury.
 - d. to live a life of fulfillment.
5. **Little leeway can be replaced with**
- a. not much extra space.
 - b. no extra space.
 - c. plenty of space.
 - d. scarcely any space.

Consider the passage below and answer the questions that follow in the light of contextual questions.

Model Question

I am always amazed when I hear people saying that sport creates goodwill among nations, and that if only the common peoples of the world could meet one another at football or squash, they would have no inclination to meet on the battle field. Even if one didn't know from concrete examples (the 1936 Olympic Games, for

instance) that international sporting contests lead to orgies of hatred, one could deduce it from general principles.

Nearly all the sports practised nowadays are competitive. You play to win, and the game has little meaning unless you do your utmost to win. On the village green, where you pick up sides and no feeling of local patriotism is involved, it is possible to play simply for the fun of it and exercise; but as soon as the question of prestige arises, as soon as you feel that you and some larger unit will be disgraced if you lose, the most savage combative instincts are aroused. Anyone who has played even in a school football match knows this. At the international level, sport is frankly a mimic warfare. But the significant thing is not the behaviour of the players but the attitude of the spectators; and, the spectators of the nations who work themselves into furies over these absurd contests and seriously believe - at any rate for short periods - that running, jumping and kicking a ball are tests of national virtue.

Even a leisurely game demanding grace rather than strength can cause much ill-will. Football, a game in which everyone gets hurt and every nation has its own style of play is far worse. Worst of all is boxing. One of the most horrible sights in the world is a fight between white and coloured boxers before a mixed audience.

1. **The 1936 Olympic Games was cited in the passage as an example to show that sports can**

- a. lead to excessive hatred.
- b. create goodwill among nations.
- c. generate feelings of national prestige.
- d. make people meet on the battle field.

2. **According to the passage,**

- a. all the sports practised nowadays are competitive.
- b. games have meaning only when the participants play to win.

it is possible to play a game simply for the fun of it.
on the local green, you play not to win but for the fun of it.

c.

d.

3.

Boxing is regarded as the worst game in the passage because

a.

b.

c.

d.

of the behaviour of the boxers themselves.

of the amount of ill-will that can be generated among spectators of different races.

of the ill-will that can be generated by a game that demands strength from the competitors.

it is a game in which both players get hurt rather badly.

4.

Which of the following statements is TRUE according to the passage?

a.

b.

c.

d.

Running, jumping and kicking a ball are tests of national virtue.

At the national level, sport is frankly a mimic warfare.

The most savage combative instincts are aroused by anyone who has played in a school football match.

Nations work themselves up because they tend to believe that sports are tests of national virtue.

5.

Mimic, as used in the passage, means

a.

b.

c.

d.

comic.

silent.

imitated.

practised.

Note: Try the next passage also.

Model Question

Undergraduate students in psychology and education come to their first course in statistics with diverse expectations of and backgrounds in Mathematics. Some have considerable formal training and quantitative aptitude and look forward to learning statistics. Others - perhaps the majority, including some of those who aspire to postgraduate studies - are less confident in their quantitative skills. They regard a course in statistics as a necessary evil for the understanding or carrying out of research in their chosen fields, but an evil nonetheless.

This third edition, like its predecessor, is directed primarily at the latter audience. It was written with the conviction that statistical concepts can be described simply without loss of accuracy and that understanding of statistical techniques as research tools can be effectively promoted by discussing them within the context of their application to concrete data rather than as pure abstractions. Further, its contents are limited to those statistical techniques that are widely used in the literature of psychology and to the principles underlying them.

The changes that have been made in this edition reflect both the results of our teaching experience and the increasing prominence being given by statisticians to certain topics. Thus, our discussions of some procedures, particularly those in the realm of descriptive statistics, which students grasp easily, have been shortened or rearranged. The treatment of other topics has been expanded. Greater emphasis has been placed on sampling theory, hypothesis testing, and the notion of statistical power.

1. **The book discussed in this passage is about**
 - a. psychology and education.
 - b. mathematics for undergraduate students.
 - c. quantitative skills for postgraduate students.
 - d. statistical procedure relating to research.

2. **The expression, 'necessary evil', means that**
- a. evil is essential in studying the subject discussed.
 - b. studying the subject is an unpleasant experience which must be endured.
 - c. only those who are evil can understand the subject.
 - d. those lacking in quantitative skills see the subject as an evil.

3. **From the passage, we learn that the book discussed has been**

- a. reprinted twice.
- b. published three times.
- c. rewritten three times.
- d. revised twice.

4. **The changes that we made in the book were motivated by**

- a. professional experience and popularity of topics.
- b. teaching experience and statisticians' views of some topics.
- c. the examination results of previous generation of students.
- d. the need to avoid areas which students grasp easily.

5. **It can be inferred from the passage that the book was written by**

- a. an educational psychologist.
- b. more than one author.
- c. a prominent statistician.
- d. a professor of statistics.

HOW TO ARRIVE AT THE CORRECT ANSWER UNDER COMPREHENSION

Immediately a candidate comes face to face with a comprehension passage, what is the step-by-step approach to getting the correct answer?

THE BASIC ATTACK METHOD

Here, a list of step-by-step ways is presented. Over the years – even from the primary school days, candidates had been told to “read the passage, first and, for effective understanding, read twice”. This approach can help only primary school pupils.

Imagine that someone asked you to go into a large hall, without further instructions. You are most likely, therefore, to go into the hall and stand there, looking blank and joblessly tired. But imagine that you were asked to go into the hall and fetch a chair, a duster and an exercise book. Sure! Immediately you get into the hall, your preoccupation would be, to look for those items, without wasting time.

A comprehension passage can be compared to a large hall and the questions you are asked under it can be compared to the item (chair, duster and exercise book) that you have been asked to fetch. If you are not asked to look for anything in particular, it will be useless reading the passage. This goes to show that, before we read a passage, we should know what we are looking for (i.e. questions). It is therefore inappropriate to read the passage first. Reading the passage first also wastes time because after the first reading, you would read the questions before you then go to the passage. Follow the Basic Attack Method outlined here.

1. **Read all the questions under a passage** (without reading the options) carefully and thoughtfully, concentrating on the questions. You should try to understand what you are required to do or what the question means. To understand the

questions, you may translate them or break each down as if you were doing an analysis, e.g. Question. "Why does Olumba usually look up whenever he addresses anybody?" You will break it down in your mind this way:

There is someone called Olumba. He usually looks up. (not just at any time but when he talks to people) What reason has been given in the passage for this habit? Why does he do it; why does he not look downwards or sideways – why upwards? Doing this assures you that you have understood the question perfectly.

Simply try not to forget any of the five or so questions you have read. Under this passage. This means that, after reading all the five questions, before you go into the passage, you must be able to recount the questions – without looking back in the book. Recount them off-hand.

Also, determine the questioning method used in framing each question: authorial, contextual, periphrastic and so on.

2. **Read the passage for the first time.** While you read the passage, use theories of passage analysis.

Ask yourself:

What is the subject matter?

What is the theme – or,

Are there any difficult words?

What are their meanings?

Are there any extra-grammatical items,

e.g idioms, metaphors etc.?

What are their meanings?

By the time you have resolved all these, it will have been certain that you have perfectly understood the passage. Meanwhile, you have not forgotten any of the five questions that you read before. You will notice that, as you read the passage for the first time, you will come across answers to the questions which you have

memorised because the moment your mind crosses anything relating to any of the questions your mind has stored, the answer will be supplied immediately. You are likely to say: "Oh, this part seems to give answer to question three which says: Why does Olumba usually look up whenever he discusses with people?" Even in such a case that some answers surrender themselves to you, you should not be so hasty as to quickly shade them in.

3. **Read the questions again.** Cross-check whether the answer you proffered is reasonable. If however, the passage is not completely clear to you, read the second time.
4. **Assemble all your answers.** They are, as I have warned, not the correct answers until you have proved them right with evidence. Now, prove your answers with the theory of evidence

THE THEORY OF EVIDENCE

Using theories to arrive at the correct answer

Up to this stage, you have nominated certain answers and are optimistic that they will pass the test of evidence. But, do not simply insist on any one option as correct just because you feel that is the answer. It should be your answer only, if there is evidence in its support.

An accused person is usually treated – or is supposed to be treated – as innocent by the police until he is arraigned before a trial judge. So also is your "accused" answer which is now in the court of Evidence. You are the trial judge.

The theory of evidence provides that one of the two types of reasons shown under here must be sought to back up any answer chosen, otherwise, the answer chosen is as good as wrong. No judge should ever send an accused to jail without evidence of guilt!

I have always taught that once there is no evidence for your answer, then, forget about scoring a mark. I have always illustrated with this sketch of dramatic reality: That, in a college, (and this is

a true – life story) there was a male professor and a female – very beautiful female – student that he was interested in befriending.

The professor had always failed this lady in any test or assignment he gave to her class, in the hope that she would, one day, come into his office and seek favour for marks. Yes, the professor was right – after failing her four times in pre-examination tests that all carried 40 marks (she had scored only 5/40), she came knocking at the professor's door. So, the following dialogue ensued:

Professor: Can I help you young lady?

Lady: (now twisting, squeezing and contorting her face the women's way): Sir, bbb... but I don't know why I've always failed your test.

Professor: Problems disappear immediately the right solutions are proffered.

Lady: So what can I do (while only teasing him).

Professor: I'll be at XYZ hotel this evening 8.30p.m. Join me? Well, if you do, 5/40 can change to 39.5/40 overnight. I'm the A to Z, Alpha and Omega, on this course in this department.

Unknown to the emotionally charged and dirty-minded professor, the lady had reported the matter to her brother (an Army Intelligence Officer) who gave her an electronic, recording pen. During the discussion (above), the lady had switched on the pen and had recorded all the discussion.

Lady: Ok, Sir, I'll be there. (still teasing him). I hope after our conference in the hotel room, my destiny will change; my marks will rise!

Professor: Certainly, I can do whatever I want with my course!

Lady: Okay, see you then.

Immediately she left the professor's office, she headed straight for the college's senate chairman's office to make a formal report of the professor who had been victimizing and sexually harassing her.

Of course, the senate sent for the professor who flatly denied ever saying any such thing to the lady. According to him, he had never seen the lady face-to-face even once in his life. What a smart play boy!

However, the lady brought out her electronic, recording pen and got one professor in the senate to play it in the hearing of everyone.

Cacophonously, the sound blared out from the pen's speaker compartment:

I'll be at the XYZ hotel this evening, 8.30p.m. Join me? If you do, 5/40 can change to 39.5/40 overnight... I'm the alpha and omega on this course in this department ... ZZZZZZ

The senate chambers went into a dead silence as they listened to the professor's voice. The professor was disciplined by the senate that also ordered that the lady's previous tests be remarked. Of course, she scored 31.5/40 in all and she subsequently graduated that year!.

Answer this question: If the lady had not got evidence (the electronic recording pen), would she have been passed by the senate; would she have got the confidence to face the professor; would she not have been sued for character assassination; defamation and slander? You must have EVIDENCE for ALL your answers.

TYPES OF EVIDENCE

1. Theoretical Evidence

Theoretical evidence refers to the proof to support an answer and it is found written in the passage. Let us exemplify:

"Mr Giwa is a trader. He has a store in David's village. His store is full of things to buy. He sells milk, sugar, tea and bread."

What is Mr Giwa's occupation?

- (a) He buys articles.
- (b) He carries out his business in David's village.
- (c) He is a trader.
- (d) He has a shop full of articles.

Answer 'C'.

This is because, it is theoretically written that Mr Giwa is a trader. This type of evidence is called **actual theoretical evidence**. There is yet another called **equivalent theoretical evidence**.

You should note that, in higher examination, it is very rare for a questioner to ask a question whose answer is written in the passage word-for-word i.e. actual theoretical. These days, at your level, most types of questions you will face will deal with equivalent theoretical evidence. This means that, the correct option may not have appeared word-for word in the passage; it is the equivalent of it, e.g. still using Mr Giwa is a trader... passage (above) and the question under it. Imagine, you have the following options as answer:

- (a) He buys articles.
- (b) He does petty business.
- (c) He carries out his business in David's village.
- (d) He has a shop full of articles.

Answer 'B'

Although he does petty business does not appear in the passage, it is equivalent of ... is a trader. Only one of these two types of evidence could be found at a time.

2. Inferential Evidence

A second type of evidence that could be adduced is the one that is inferred or brought out as a result of our bringing two or more facts of the passage together for the purpose of determining what they all point to. It has to do with using the principles of logic: If this is this and that is that, then, this should be this.

Drawing logical conclusions involves finding at least two premises or theses (facts) and reconciling or considering them together, bringing out the common facts they both point to. For example, Akin is tall, about two metres tall although he is quite young – 13 years old. Yesterday, I saw him in front of their house with a very tall man and an equally tall woman – about forty-five years old each, although, the man appeared a little older than the woman described. All the three were going into the main house. More striking is their complexion – they are all very light complexioned.

Question: The man and woman described in the passage are likely to be:

- (a) Joe's friends.
- (b) members of Joe's political party.
- (c) his parents.
- (d) his brother and sister.
- (e) his neighbours.

Answer 'C'

Although **his parents** does not appear in the passage, the following premises or theses all collectively point to that fact.

- (a) Joe is 13 years old; the man and woman 45 years old each (old enough to be his parents).
- (b) They are all very tall.
- (c) They are all light complexioned.
- (d) They are all going inside the main house.

And, given option a – e. 'c' is the most appropriate. This is a simple principle of logic.

Reference: 1989 UME, Passage 1, question 1.

Passage

As the stranger approached, Shola noticed that he was handsome and her excitement increased. It was of such a man she had dreamt. He had a fine, arrogant carriage, like a soldier or someone in authority.

When he reached the end of the pier, he addressed them in a rich, deep voice that disturbed her as the voluptuous rising of the tide had done.

"You're Tunde Onu, I'm told," he said to her father.

"That's right," said her father.

"The bus conductor told me you take people to the Islands," the man continued. "I'd like to go there if you can take me."

Her father examined the man from head to foot, shrewdly measuring his capacity to pay. Then he said:

"When were you thinking of going?"

"Right away."

"That's a different story, for my boatman is gone to Badagry and he won't be back before nightfall."

"Oh! said the stranger. 'That's too bad. You couldn't get someone else instead of him?'"

"I would have to think hard," he said gloomily, "for it's not everyone would do for the job of going with me beyond the bay of the Islands at this time of the year." Shola understood her father's manoeuvre and felt ashamed.

1. **How would you describe Shola's father?**

- a. a greedy boatman.
- b. an energetic but good-for-nothing man.
- c. a loving father who wants to safeguard the interest of his daughter.
- d. a talkative fool.

2. **Which of the following is NOT true of the passage?**

- a. Shola did not approve of her father's behaviour towards the stranger.
- b. Shola's father could row the stranger to the Islands alone had he so wished.
- c. Shola's father exaggerated the difficulties in order to raise his fee.

- d. Shola had recently been disturbed by the tide.
3. Which of the following is true of the stranger in the passage?
- a. He was a proud and good looking man with a deep voice that annoyed Shola.
- b. He was familiar with the people of the Islands.
- c. He was a fine gentleman in need of help.
- d. He was too proud to reciprocate Shola's love.
4. **Manoeuvre in the passage means**
- a. shrewdness.
- b. cleverness.
- c. stupidity.
- d. strategy.
5. Which of the following is true of the passage?
- a. The stranger was in a bad mood.
- b. The stranger came by bus.
- c. Shola and her father were idle when the stranger came.
- d. Shola's father measured the stranger from head to foot.

Comment: How would you describe Shola's father – considering everything he did and said in the passage? What are the points in support of your answer? Remember, question 1 is an **evaluation question**. Can you put facts together and consider them, logically?

Errors when using Logic or Inferential Evidence

Logic, as stressed, uses at least two "theses" or "premises". But in drawing a conclusion, the following errors may arise and prevent the reader from arriving at the correct answer:

Hasty Conclusions

- (i) This arises when a conclusion is drawn after considering only few cases, not all cases, e.g.
Peter knows Dr Williams.
Randy knows Dr Williams.
Dammy Knows Dr Williams.

It will be a hasty conclusion to assert that: **Everybody in the class knows Dr Williams**. You will find out that only three people have been tested – compared to the large number of students in the school. It is safer to say:

Some students know Dr Williams. Compare **some** with **everybody**.

(ii) Fallacy of Opposing Facts

This occurs when a statement tends to mean that if someone does not do something, it would not be done. It is fallacious, for example, to state that if Thomas Edison did not discover electricity, there would not be electricity today. Why? If he did not, there were chances someone else would have done it. The failure of one does not exclude the success of another.

(iii) Unmarked Generalisations

Look at this for example – We must tell the truth when we deal with others. Good. But is it at all times that telling the truth pays off? No! There are certain times when we would be expected to tell lies to save a situation. For example, a man chases his wife with a sharp machete, ready to behead her. She runs into my room to hide. The husband comes screaming, demanding, between heavy breaths: "Is the mad woman in your room?"

"No," I would say. At least, it is not advisable to tell the truth in this kind of situation. So, watch out for generalised situations and see whether what you are dealing with is marked e.g. **tell the truth** is general, **tell the truth in many cases** (not always) is marked – to show that it is not all the time that truth should be told.

(IV) Crippled Syllogism

This refers to a situation where a wrong conclusion – an inadequate, inappropriate conclusion – is drawn from two theses. It remains **illogical** to say:

(a) St Mary's is a girls' school.

(b) Martha is a girl.

$a + b (=)$ therefore **Martha is a student at St Mary's**, but logical to say:

(a) Martha is a girl.

(b) All girls attend St. Mary's.

$a + b =$ therefore, **Martha is a student at St Mary's**.

PASSAGES FOR PRACTICE

In practising with these passages, attempt to read them appropriately, determine the questioning method used in each question, recall the attack method, use the appropriate theory of evidence and do justice.

PASSAGE 1

In his own days, Nostradamus was acknowledged as the greatest seer alive and even today, he is often labelled as the most important prophet of European civilization. Many of his predictions, made public in the 1950s, appear to have come true. But what really sets Nostradamus apart is the specificity of his forecasts. He named names. Pasteure, Napoleon, Hitler, all, were mentioned in his writings centuries before their births.

Born on December 13, 1503 at St. Remy, France, Michael de Nostradame (he later latinised his name to Nostradamus) was the son of a well-to-do notary public. He was a devout catholic and at 21, he enrolled as a medical student at the Prestigious University of Montpellier. Two years later, the Black Plague ravaged Southern France, prompting Nostradamus' leaving medical school to treat victims of the epidemic. His highly successful work in arresting the

Plague won him national fame. He then returned to school and earned a medical degree.

Suddenly, his wife and two of his children died and, blaming himself for the loss of his family, he left France for other places, occasionally practising medicine and consulting with philosophers and astrologers. While in Italy, he spotted a young Franciscan friar named Felice Peretti and abruptly knelt before him saying I must kneel before His Holiness. In 1585, 19 years after Nostradamus' death Peretti was elected Pope Sixtus.

His premier prediction to come true was the death of Henry II of France: The young lion shall overcome the old in martial field by a single duel... and shall die he a cruel death.

In 1559, Henry II was mortally wounded simultaneously in the eye and throat during a friendly joust with a young Scater Guard whose lance accidentally penetrated the visor of the King's golden helmet. (From the *Book of Predictions* by Amy Wallace.)

1. **Nostradamus drifted from France for the first time because**

- (a) he wanted to go and practise medicine.
- (b) he was hunted by feelings of negligence to his lost family.
- (c) it was necessary for him to gain more experience of medicine outside France.
- (d) he loved his wife and children that were lost.
- (e) All of the above.

2. **Nostradamus broke up his schooling because**

- (a) it was usual in problem situations.
- (b) he was called upon to help treat victims of the Black Plague.
- (c) of the outbreak of the Black Plague.
- (d) he chose to lend a hand in treating Black Plague victims.
- (e) he wanted to win awards even as a student.

3. Which of the following is TRUE according to the passage?

- (a) Nostradamus won international honours for successfully treating victims of the plague.
- (b) His grandfather enrolled him in a school of astrology.
- (c) He was the son of a notable public officer.
- (d) He was a brilliant and respectful medical student.
- (e) He became popular in France after the Black Plague.

4. Nostradamus' first proved prophecy was of

- (a) a French Monarch.
- (b) Henry Felice Peretti.
- (c) Pope Sixtus V.
- (d) his successful treating of Black Plague victims.
- (e) the death of members of his family.

5. How would you describe Nostradamus?

- (a) A pompous medical officer who tried to be seen by people.
- (b) A generous and scrupulous prophet.
- (c) The most important figure in European civilization.
- (d) Jack of all trade.
- (e) An unintelligent but much loved seer.

PASSAGE II

I cannot but shuffle back in memory, to reminisce my school days at St. John's Grammar school.

In those days... before education became a thing of concession and not of conviction, the school which a student attended mattered in a systematic and careful consideration or determination of his character, intelligence and, generally, personality.

Before I was admitted to the least populous but most popular dream school of all students at the time, the old Reverend Father Fabian Cloutier invited me for an oral interview, having found me

mettlesome in the written test. But even if one did well in the written test but had a tied tongue for spoken English, his chances of admission started, thenceforth, to fall off.

Once a registered student of the most prestigious high school of its type around Western State, I assumed the philosophy and posture of a confident, dutiful, obedient and promising student. But it was not long before the older boys who had become a stick of dried fish brought my head into their coterie. In no time at all, I had excelled at leaving school assignment undone and become, most sincerely, an incurable late comer to school, who would come to the school campus only to retreat to the jungle, eating and drinking leaving our reading while Miss Donoghue, our French Mistress from France, laboured in vain to teach the absentees, that we were, a strange tongue.

But, once Fr. Cloutier spotted me on a branch in the jungle forest, he simply took me to his dreaded office and, what he did to me was what made me become a patient, for three weeks, at a local hospital ... and that changed all my life for the better.

1. **Rev. Cloutier could be described as**

- (a) a wicked man.
- (b) a specialist in interviewing.
- (c) one who knew good education and was a disciplinarian.
- (d) a simple but loving educationist.
- (e) all of the above.

2. **Which of the following is NOT true according to the passage?**

- (a) The writer was brilliant.
- (b) The writer was adventurous.
- (c) The writer was incorruptible.
- (d) The writer was an admirable personality at the beginning.
- (e) None of these.

3. Strange tongue means

- (a) good manners.
- (b) unusual language.
- (c) our lessons.
- (d) uncommon subject.
- (e) how to speak in tongues.

4. It is implied in the passage that

- (a) people are now forced to school against their wish.
- (b) students have genuine likeness for education now.
- (c) the standard of education has now fallen.
- (d) education in those days was confusing.
- (e) more people are quitting school, nowadays.

5. A suitable title for this passage is

- (a) St John's Grammar school.
- (b) Rev. Fr Cloutier.
- (c) A High school Diary.
- (d) Education in the past.
- (e) St John's: Its teachers and principal.

PASSAGE III

One athlete whose every activity has made good copies for newshounds and whose country of origin has completely eclipsed her phenomenal exploits on the tracks is Zola Budd. She was 15 when she began hugging the headlines in 1982 as the barefooted wonder from Bloemfontein in South Africa. Six years later, Budd still creates waves but of a different kind. The kind that has now left her promising running career in shambles and her heart in misery. And all this because of her enduring romance with apartheid even four years after she was granted a British citizenship. Stumbling from one controversy to the other in the last six weeks, Budd temporarily decided to call it quits with athletics and headed for South Africa early in May, on a self-imposed exile. It was the climax

of a series of events that had placed the career of the 21-year-old world record holder in the 5,000 metres in a cul-de-sac.
Culled from **Newswatch (1985)**

1. **Newshounds means**

- (a) newsreaders.
- (b) newspaper vendors.
- (c) newsmakers.
- (d) journalists.
- (e) dogs that carry news.

2. **It is true that originally, Budd was NOT**

- (a) a South African.
- (b) a British Citizen.
- (c) 15 when she got to Britain.
- (d) a seasoned sprinter.
- (e) exiled to South Africa.

3. **Her running career is hitting the rocks because**

- (a) she makes love to many people.
- (b) she now loves romance more than running.
- (c) she still has racial inclinations.
- (d) the Britons hate South Africans.
- (e) she hates apartheid.

4. **Budd is now**

- (a) in South Africa.
- (b) reaching the climax of her ambition.
- (c) banished from Britain.
- (d) no more an athlete.
- (e) a South African.

5. **What brought Budd to limelight?**

- (a) Her British citizenship.
- (b) Journalists.
- (c) Her admirers.
- (d) Her diligence.
- (e) A series of controversies.

PASSAGE IV

Even if the most ambitious programme of studies of the lives and contributions of individual African rulers, statesmen and religious leaders could be carried out, we should still be a long way from achieving a reasonable understanding of African history. The principle that the paramount chiefs, nobility, and top people generally cannot be studied in order to put African history right is as valid for Africa as it is for Europe.

Until we know a great deal more about the conditions of the people: vassal tribes, slaves, with their differing degrees of servitude, free commoners, the rank-and-file of the army in the various African states at successive periods, we shall remain very much in the dark about the character of these systems and of the causes of the changes which they have undergone. But until very recently, such questions have scarcely been raised – let alone answered.

Culled from M. J. Charke's *English Studies Series*.

1. **According to the passage, one can comprehend African history fully,**

- (a) by reading about great Africans and their work.
- (b) by consulting authorities who could put history right.
- (c) examining the lives and contributions of African rulers, statesmen and other important people.
- (d) by going to Europe where adequate records of African history are kept.
- (e) None of the above.

2. **Partial evaluation of African history would be made by**

- (a) judging the African past.
- (b) considering the least important people's lives.
- (c) evaluating the contribution of kings and their vassals.
- (d) having hope in future.
- (e) All of the above.

3. ... the rank and file of the army ... in the statement means

- (a) the least rated soldiers.
- (b) the generality of soldiers highly placed or low ranking.
- (c) the soldiers who specialise in carrying files about.
- (d) the bosses.
- (e) those who did not start as recruits.

4. '... let alone answered' – in the sentence shows that

- (a) the questions cannot be answered.
- (b) the questions have been left alone.
- (c) the questions were not answered because the questions were not raised.
- (d) it will take courageous people to answer the question.
- (e) although many questions have been raised only one has been answered.

5. Which of the following is NOT true?

- (a) Ambitious and elaborate programmes on African elite may not give us insight into African history.
- (b) Careful research regarding kings, scholars, eminent Africans and consultation with historians can help us understand African history.
- (c) The history of Europe cannot be understood adequately.
- (d) The history of Africa cannot be exhaustively understood.
- (e) (b) and (c) above.

PASSAGE V

We cannot deny knowing some people whose virtue is close to those of some saints. Even if our people – the local and sophisticated ones have tried at their post, working fruitlessly to manufacture some sort of scientific mystique or lead the world creating human beings just as scientists in America have started doing, they could still be proud of being able to achieve something that even world powers have not achieved. It is a great sight looking at a man or woman as the case may be in a black shirt and a black

cap. A black rope is, in either case, tied around the waist with a steel of death in his or her hand. Inside the steel of death resides boiling lead and the holder puts his hand at the trigger, ready to shoot. Behold, that is what we have to show to the world. But more important is what the man or woman I have just described does, than what he or she is: with the hand secretly slipped behind the back, where an erring highway driver (whose excesses he has been charged to watch) stands, he takes as meager an amount as twenty naira even when the erring driver had committed manslaughter! And the actor here does it with the expertise of a connoisseur in bribe taking and with impunity.

1. The tone of this passage is

- (a) that of outright condemnation.
- (b) non-committal.
- (c) critical.
- (d) satirical.
- (e) that of approval.

2. 'steel of death' according to the passage means

- (a) piece of wood used for beating animals to death.
- (b) a baton.
- (c) a gun.
- (d) a strong cane.
- (e) a rod.

3. The man and woman described in this passage are likely to be

- (a) committed civil servants.
- (b) friends of drivers.
- (c) corrupt law-enforcement officers.
- (d) saintly and respectable people.
- (e) incorruptible people.

The theme of this passage is

4. A man and a woman in black uniform.
(a) Corruption.
(b) Excellence of our people.
(c) Incorruptibility.
(d) Saintly behaviour.
(e)

According to the writer of the passage,

5. the law frowns on the attitude of the professionals mentioned.
(b) the attitude of the professionals described here is not usually challenged.
(c) it is a pride for the people who watch the professionals.
(d) these professionals should continue in their present activities.

COMPREHENSION PRACTICALS

MODEL QUESTIONS AND ANALYSED ANSWERS

This part forms the crux of the explanation we have been making from the beginning.

In this section, attempt has been made to answer past and model questions (on different comprehension passages here) the way you are expected to do it so as to arrive at the correct — and nothing but the correct — answer.

As emphasized, you must stringently guard against any careless loss of marks under comprehension. Each such loss is a great loss indeed: three marks gone!

You are to follow and master the approach we have given to the questions here.

First, determine the type of passage you are dealing with: **original** or **adaptation**.

Second, the **BASIC ATTACK METHOD** must be tenaciously followed:

- (a) Read the questions and understand them. What questioning method has been used to form it?
- (b) Do not forget them.
- (c) Read the passage for the first time with the questions you have read still freshly remembered (note that if you do not follow this pattern, all answer – options, at the end of the day, will be competing for your attention, each, “a” to “d” saying, “I am the correct option.” At the end of the day the candidate is confused. Avoid confusion. Follow the steps. As you read the passage, note strange, long words, phrases, idioms and so on. You must understand each of them.

(d) Note, as you read the passage, likely possible answers to the questions that you have lodged in your mind, will be showing up. These have been described as "accused" answers and like "accused" persons at police stations, there should be evidence obtained or exhibited in a court of law.

(e) Now, move to the "court" of evidence where you will apply the "theory of evidence". By now, you are expected to have understood entirely, how to operate, the theory of evidence:

Finding theses A & B or A, B & C

Comparing and combining theses A & B or A, B & C

Finding an additional thesis (an offshoot of the combination of A & B or A, B & C).

For example, to establish the correct answer (do not be deceived, this is how JAMB arrives at answers to comprehension passages, themselves), compare thesis A & B and arrive at synthesis C. By now, you know how to look for **actual theoretical evidence**, **equivalent theoretical evidence** and **inferential evidence**. If you have not fully mastered these, it is evidence that you are not ready for JAMB's comprehension. Flip back in this book, read and master this aspect.

Let me also remind you that your ability to know and determine the type of question method used in framing questions under any comprehension passage carries a large percentage of your chances at arriving at the correct answer.

Let us put it this way:

- i 15% – Getting to understand the demands / meaning of each question.
- ii. 25% – Reading and understanding the passage well.
- iii 25% – Understanding the questioning method used in forming each question.

iv **35%** – Successfully applying the theory of evidence and being sure of your answer through it.

100% – Correct answer.

The above represents an attempt at arriving at 100% - correct answer to each question under comprehension.

Now, which of (i) to (iv) above can you afford to disregard? None!

By far, the most important is the use of the theory of evidence.

Laid out under here are treatises of past questions with comments on them in form of a model. You are advised to strictly adhere to the pattern used below in the book so that you can confidently do it yourself in the examination hall.

Model Question

"You all know how friendly we are with Okperi. Do you think that any Umuaro man who goes to prison there will come back alive? But that apart, do you forget that this is the moon of planting? Do you want to grow this year's crops in the prison house in a land where your fathers owe a cow? I speak as your elder brother. I have travelled in Olu and I have travelled in Igbo, and I can tell you that there is no escape from the white man. He has come. When suffering knocks at your door and you say there is no seat left for him, he tells you not to worry because he has brought his own stool. The white man is like that. Before any of you here was old enough to tie a cloth between the legs I saw with my own eyes what the white man did to Abame. Then I knew there was no escape. As daylight chases away darkness so will the white man drive away all our customs? I know that as I say it now it passes by your ears, but it will happen. The white man has power, which comes from the true God, and it burns like fire. This is the God about whom we preach every eighth-day...Unachukwu's opponents were now shouting that this was a meeting of an age group that they had not assembled to join with him in chewing the seed of foolishness, which they called their new religion."

"We are talking about the white man's road," said a voice above the others.

"Yes, we are talking about the white man's road. But when the roof and walls of a house fall in, the ceiling is not left standing. The white man, the new religion, the soldiers, the new road — they are all part of the same thing. The white man has a gun, a machete, a bow and carries fire in his mouth. He does not fight with one weapon alone."

1. **The dominant subject of this passage is the**

- a. White man's road.
- b. New religion.
- c. White man's influence.
- d. White man's weapons.

2. **According to the passage, the people of Umuaro and Okperi**

- a. are friends.
- b. are only acquaintances.
- c. are no friends.
- d. can never be enemies.

3. **"There is no escape from the white man" in the passage means that the**

- a. white man will send the people to prison.
- b. white man can kill all the people with his gun.
- c. people are only trying to run away from the white man.
- d. people must accept the white man.

4. **"Passes by your ears" in the passage means**

- a. piercing through your ears.
- b. listening eagerly.
- c. making no impression.
- d. accepting as the truth.

5. **Unachukwu's speech in this passage shows that he**

- a. is a coward.
- b. wants his people to suffer.

- c. loves the white man.
- d. is wise with experience.

Comments

As a candidate in this examination, you have read and understood all the questions. That is the first thing. Still under this first step, you have noted, by the side of each question, the type of questioning method that has been used by JAMB. You have not forgotten that **EVERY QUESTION** has a questioning method. You have also noted that once you do not know the questioning method involved, the answer is yours. You should therefore proceed to determine the type of question method used under this passage.

Question 1: The dominant subject of this passage is the ...? In other words, what is the theme (dominant subject) of this passage? This is a **suitability question**. A suitability question can ask you about **theme**, a **suitable topic**, **tone**, **mood** or **subject of discussion**.

Also, don't forget the approach to this type of question. Remember that you have to consider the totality and entirety of the subject matter and see what they all point to: whether we consider the new religion or the white man's road or the soldiers, they all, according to this passage, originate from "the white man", so, the answer is the great influence of the white man in Africa – "C".

Question 2: According to the passage, the people of Umuaro and Okperi ...

To put the question in another form; what, according to the passage, is the relationship between the two people; can you evaluate their character and inter-relationship? So, this question is an **Evaluation question**. How?

Remember that, an evaluation question would want you to weigh, determine or assess a person, people, a place or an event. Also remember, now, that the question above pertains to people. So, you must evaluate from the point of view of characterization; which is done by:

- (a) considering what the people have said, one to the other, about themselves or regarding the other group/people.
- (b) what outsiders say about them.
- (c) how they have spoken.
- (d) what each group has done to itself or to the other group.

After considering what this Umuaro speaker said about the Okperi people (consider the irony in the first sentence and read the first four sentences), you realize that the relationship between them is sour and the closest option to this assertion is "C" (are no friends). The theory of evidence (if you would quickly apply it now) supports "C", completely.

Question 3: "There is no escape from the white man" in the passage means that the...

To put the question in another form, what, in the context in which this clause is found, is its meaning?

This is a **contextual question**! Certainly, you have not forgotten that contextual questions may involve one, two or three individual words; it may involve a phrase or it may also involve a clause (such as the one above). You know that the question, which is contextual in orientation, will ask you to give the meaning of such word, phrase or clause, not in isolation, but in relation – close relation – to the whole context of the passage.

Therefore, **there is no escape from the white man** on its own may mean many things but considering all the influence, power and susceptibility of the white man over the people, his powers are overwhelming.

Question 4: **Passes by your ears** in the passage means...?

In other words, in the context where it appears, what does "**passes by your ears**" mean?

This, as you know, is a contextual question as question 3 is.

In this context, if you choose option "C", I support you.

Question 5:

Unachukwu's speech in this passage shows that he ...?

In other words, how would you weigh or assess or evaluate Unachukwu's speech. By all manner of means, this is an evaluational question.

You can arrive at the answer by considering his warnings and advice to his tribesmen. Can you point at or underline, at least, four sentences in the passage that show that Unachukwu is wise with experience? **Option D**, the correct option.

PERIPHRASTIC questions are not straight forward as others, as you have learnt. They have tendencies for confusing the candidate from the outset. As aforesaid, a periphrastic question is framed in a round – about, crooked manner but YOU have the responsibility of straightening it, reframing it so that you can understand the demands of the question before you go ahead to answer the question.

1983 passage 1, questions 2 and 5 are instructive here.

Question 2 under this passage asks:

Unless it can be shown that the money voted for projects can be spent on them in good time... (a) , (b) , (c) , (d) , (e).

In other words, the responsibility devolves on you to reframe it: if (to replace unless) it can NOT be shown that the money ... can be spent ... in good time..., what will happen?

You have been consistently warned to ensure that you reframe a question to the level of your own understanding.

Consider, under the same passage, question 5:

Which of these is not among the reasons given by the author for enumerating the examples of the current development?

This, at first sight, looks like a **REFUTATIONAL** question but it combines vestiges of the **PERIPHRASTIC** question.

AUTHORIAL questions are to be carefully dealt with. They may, as you know, tempt you to use your personal ideas, views or judgement about a particular issue or subject matter rather than relying on the provisions of the passage and views of the passage writer.

Let us take, for example, the 1981 passage D below.

PASSAGE

This book consists of lectures given by me at Cambridge. Though they have been largely rewritten, I have kept a good deal of their original lecture-form, as being (I hope) rather less formal and less dogmatic. For to dogmatism, those who write on language seem, for some reason, particularly prone; and I should like to make it clear at once that, if at times I have put my views strongly, I do not forget that such matters of taste must remain mere matters of opinion.

In addition, I have included a good many specimen passages from various authors. Perhaps I have quoted too much. But a book on style without abundant examples seems to me as ineffectual as a book on art, or biology without abundant illustrations. Many of these passages are in French. That may be Gallomania on my part; and I must apologize if they trouble some readers. But some ability to read French prose does seem to me most desirable for anyone who would write well in English. I have tried to choose pieces not too difficult in syntax or vocabulary. And in these days less than ever can we afford to be insular.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult words?
- (e) difficult idioms?
- (f) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (g) difficult proverbs?
- (h) types of questioning method used?

Questions

1. According to the author (in this preface) the book is
 - a. the original version of his Cambridge lectures.
 - b. a revised version of his Cambridge lectures.

- c. an imitation of his Cambridge lectures.
- d. a negation of his Cambridge lectures.
- e. an authentic version of his Cambridge lectures.

2. **The author says that writers on language are**

- a. inclined to be dogmatic.
- b. opposed to dogmatism.
- c. unlikely to be dogmatic.
- d. resolved to be dogmatic.
- e. ready to be dogmatic.

3. **In the author's opinion, a book on style**

- a. can do with few examples.
- b. need not have any examples.
- c. is a book on art.
- d. will be ineffectual with many examples.
- e. will be ineffectual with insufficient examples.

4. **To write English well, the author says it is helpful to**

- a. be able to write French fairly well.
- b. be able to read French fairly well.
- c. know French thoroughly.
- d. be able to read English well.
- e. do all of the above.

5. **Our understanding of the last sentences in the passage is that we**

- a. can now afford to be insular.
- b. can be insular in future.
- c. cannot afford to be insular.
- d. must never be insular.
- e. must now be more insular.

Comment

Can you attempt to say what type of questioning method is used to frame each of the questions 1, 2, 3 and 4?

All the questions mentioned above are **authorial** questions.

From the standpoint of your knowledge of the questioning method, you are not far from the answers. Now, answer the questions above.

LOGICAL questions as questions, which task your knowledge of the use of logic, will be abundant in your examination.

Your ability to compare theses, one with the other and arrive at a synthesis will here see you through. Passage 1 of 1982 UME, questions 1, 2 and 4 are instructive here. Still ahead in this book you will find that passage fully typed out. Now that you know that these questions are logical questions you should attempt to answer them, keeping behind your mind that the correct answers will thrive on the theses you are able to identify. Further, let us take passage E of 1981.

Dear John,

Many thanks for your letter. I was very glad to hear that you had done so well in your examinations. Let me send you my hearty congratulations. You certainly deserved this result, as I know you worked very hard.

You asked how I have been spending the time since I took my examinations. I have been waiting so eagerly for the results that, I must admit, I have not done half the things I planned to do during this extended holiday.

However, I have been doing a lot of reading. There were so many different things I was interested in when I was at school and did not have the time to read about because they were not on the syllabus. I have read two books about geology, which is a fascinating subject. I hope to make a hobby of geology when I get to the University. It will make a change from the study of law; I have also read several novels, mostly modern ones by authors like Graham Greene, C.S. Forester and Somerset Maugham. How enjoyable it

is to read a book for pleasure and not for an examination! I have not given a thought to law, and not read one book about the subject. I shall have four long years at the University to devote to it.

I have also been going once or twice a week to the National Boys' Club. I took part in the table tennis tournament, but I did not do very well, I'm afraid. I have been playing football for the Club every Sunday afternoon.

I will certainly let you know my examination results as soon as I have them. I must say that I become less confident about the results each day. It was encouraging to hear that this was the case with you, and since you did so well perhaps there is still hope for me!

Yours sincerely,

Osman.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult words?
- (e) difficult idioms?
- (f) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (g) difficult proverbs?
- (h) types of questioning method used?

Questions

1. John deserved to pass his examinations because
 - a. the examinations were easy.
 - b. he was a brilliant student.
 - c. he prepared very well for it.
 - d. he was a lucky student.
 - e. the examiner was very liberal.

2. **You will regard Osman during term time as a student who reads**
all types of books.

- a. always.
- b. all the subjects on the curriculum.
- c. much more than other students.
- d. only the books that are prescribed.
- e.

3. **Osman couldn't do most of what he had planned for the holidays because**

- a. he thought he would fail.
- b. he was afraid of failure.
- c. waiting for the results made him sick.
- d. his anxiety for the results made him sick.
- e. he could not find anything else to do.

4. **From the passage, we can see that Osman intends to become**

- a. a very learned man.
- b. the cleverest man in his family.
- c. a lawyer.
- d. the chief magistrate of his district.
- e. a writer of books.

5. **Osman became less confident of his result each day but that does not mean that**

- a. he will pass.
- b. he will fail.
- c. he is a coward.
- d. he is hopeless.
- e. he is lazy.

Questions 1, 3, 4 and 5 are logical questions. But let us specifically take question 4, which asks: From the passage, we can see that Osman intends to become ... In other words, what do you think Osman intends to become? You should be careful not to confuse

this question with: What career /profession will Osman be pursuing?
Right, we have heard that Osman will study law but that is not what the question affects.

Now, let us fish out the useful theses (facts) here.

Thesis I I have been doing a lot of reading.

(He has read Literature, Geology.)

Thesis II He will study law for four years.

Thesis III He has learnt to play table tennis and football.

What will anyone who studies the subjects above finally become?
Certainly not just a lawyer but something more: a very learned person an all rounder, sort of.

Please take note of the fact that arriving at this answer is not based on any external thesis but on facts within the passage only.

In the passage (past questions) ahead in this book, look out for questions of logic and treat them the same way.

DIRECT questions are easy to approach. You only need to be sure that the theory of evidence, which you have applied, is appropriately applied. Try the following past questions from UME.

NOW, answer the following past questions yourself.

ENGLISH LANGUAGE COMPREHENSION

Read each passage carefully and the questions that follow it.

PASSAGE I

All over the world till lately, and in most of the world still today, mankind has been following the course of nature: that is to say, it has been breeding up to the maximum. To let nature take her extravagant course in the reproduction of the human race may have made sense in an age in which we were also letting her take

her course in decimating mankind by the casualties of war, pestilence, and famine. Being human, we have at last revolted against that senseless waste. We have started to impose on nature's heartless play a humane new order of our own. But, when once man has begun to interfere with nature, he cannot afford to stop half way. We cannot, with impunity, cut down the death-rate, and at the same time allow the birth-rate to go on taking nature's course. We must consciously try to establish an equilibrium or, sooner or later, famine will stalk abroad again.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult words?
- (e) difficult idioms?
- (f) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (g) difficult proverbs?
- (h) types of questioning method used?

Questions

1. **The author observes that**

- (a) war, pestilence and famine were caused by the extravagance of nature.
- (b) nature was heartless and senseless.
- (c) there was a time when uncontrolled birth made sense.
- (d) it was wise at a time when mankind did not interfere with normal production.
- (e) nature was heartless in its reproductive process.

2. **Which of these statements does not express the opinion of the author?**

- (a) Mankind has started to interfere with the work of nature.
- (b) Many people had died in the past through want and disease
- (c) Mankind should not have the maximum number of children possible.
- (d) Mankind should take care of its children.
- (e) Man's present relationship with nature in matters of birth and death is a happy one.

3. **"humane" as used in the passage means**

- (a) sensible. (b) wise. (c) human. (d) benevolent.
- (e) thorough.

4. **"We must consciously try to establish an equilibrium" means that we must**

- (a) realistically find an equation.
- (b) strive not to be wasteful.
- (c) deliberately try to fight nature.
- (d) try to fight nature.
- (e) purposely find a balance.

5. **The main idea of this passage is that**

- (a) nature is heartless.
- (b) man should control the birth-rate.
- (c) mankind will soon perish of starvation.
- (d) pestilence causes more deaths than war.
- (e) man should change nature's course gradually.

PASSAGE II

So far, I have been speaking of science in its universality viewed from the perspective of the world at large. For in the context of our own country and our sister developing countries many of the factors mentioned earlier are not very important. For example, pollution, deterioration of the environment and population explosion are not yet serious problems for us in this country.

Let me now turn to a more specific area, namely, the question of scientific choice for developing countries. There is no doubt that the role which science and technology has played in the upliftment of the material and economic well-being of the developed nations will, and does, influence the criteria that the Third World nations must choose in order to establish their science policies and priorities.

But the criteria to be used by the nations do not have to be the same as those which have brought the developed countries to their present stage of evolution. For while human beings have the same problems, their solutions, to be meaningful, will have to be sought within some relevant frame of reference, such as the available resources and expertise, social values, place and time in the historical scale.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult words?
- (e) difficult idioms?
- (f) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (g) difficult proverbs?
- (h) types of questioning method used?

1. "frame of reference" in this passage means

- (a) point of information.
- (b) range of authority.
- (c) economic pattern.
- (d) context of situation.
- (e) wholesome choice.

2. The writer apparently believes that through science and technology our country can achieve

- (a) peace and order.
- (b) progress and material success.

- (c) social values and universality.
- (d) wealth and economic progress.
- (e) military development and power.

3. **According to the passage, the basic consideration for developing science and technology should be three of the following:**

- 1. technical know-how.
 - 2. availability of raw materials.
 - 3. atmospheric pollution.
 - 4. the people's tradition and beliefs.
 - 5. population.
 - 6. capital.
- (a) 2, 1 and 6
 - (b) 3, 2 and 4 only
 - (c) 5, 3 and 6 only
 - (d) 6, 5 and 4 only
 - (e) 5, 2 and 6 only

4. **The main idea of this passage is that**

- (a) there is a yawning gap between the have's and the have-not's.
- (b) there is need to rid his countrymen from the scourges of hunger, disease, ignorance and want.
- (c) there could be atmospheric pollution and population explosion.
- (d) the concerns of science and technology are the same in all countries.
- (e) each nation must plan its development according to its needs and resources.

5. **The term 'our sister developing countries' implies**

- (a) Britain, Gambia and Canada.
- (b) Ghana, Germany and Togo.
- (c) Russia, Switzerland and America.
- (d) Liberia, Sierra-Leone and Gabon.
- (e) China, India and Holland.

PASSAGE III

I dare not lift the veil that protects our tribal marriage customs and ceremonies from the eyes of outsiders. There is already too little in this world that is sacred; and what Fatmata and I were required to go through during the next week must remain so, I was deeply in debt by the time everything was over, but I was absolutely satisfied with my parents' choice. Fatmata was as black as satin, and as soft. She had the teeth and smile of a goddess. The Dupo tutors had done their job well: she was a completely efficient lover and mother. I brought her home with swelling pride, and began at once to save all I could spare towards the cost of acquiring my second wife. My anti-Western revolt was gaining momentum.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) theme?
- (b) subject matter?
- (c) difficult words?
- (d) difficult words?
- (e) difficult idioms?
- (f) difficult phrasal verbs?
- (g) difficult proverbs?
- (h) types of questioning method used?

1. The evidence would seem to indicate that

- (a) the author adores his wife.
- (b) he disapproves of her ways.
- (c) he thinks she is extravagant.
- (d) the author regrets the cause of his debt.
- (e) she had not been properly brought up.

2. When the author said "My anti-Western revolt was gaining momentum", he was referring to the fact that

- (a) he did not like polygamy.
- (b) he hated Europeans.

- (c) he did not want to marry another wife.
- (d) he admired everything about his wife.
- (e) he revolted against European values.

3. **It would appear that the marriage had turned him into**

- (a) a good worker.
- (b) a faithful husband.
- (c) an incurable debtor.
- (d) a tragic figure.
- (e) a proud husband.

4. **Which of the following is NOT true of the passage?**

- (a) The lady was beautiful.
- (b) The marriage cost a lot of money.
- (c) The marriage was according to native law and custom.
- (d) Fatmata never had an issue.
- (e) The author wanted another wife.

25. **'swelling' means**

- (a) jovial. (b) great. (c) remarkable. (d) happy. (e) growing.

PASSAGE IV

Foreign Language learning

The learning of a foreign language should be an integral part of every university student's education. As a discipline, it affords the mind excellent training. It utilizes skills needed in so many other subjects: the concentration required for memorizing music (not to mention developing the ear for tone and pitch), the logical thinking for resolving mathematical problems, even the deductive reasoning capabilities needed to comprehend philosophical concepts. The mind is stretched through the simple act of learning the grammatical patterns, vocabulary and phonological system of a language, for while most people, perhaps the more promising of the two, are being able to understand and hopefully appreciate another

cultural group through their literature, their music and customs all of which are best assimilated through the medium of their language.

1. **An appropriate title for the article from which this passage is taken could be**

- (a) the need for foreign language learning in Universities.
- (b) an apology for the study of foreign languages in Nigeria Universities.
- (c) the need to study French and Kiswahili in our Colleges and Universities.
- (d) why a foreign language should be studied by all who study music, mathematics or philosophy.
- (e) the pros and cons of foreign language learning in Nigerian Universities.

2. **According to the passage, the main reward for a foreign language learner is**

- (a) the ability to speak another language.
- (b) being able to teach the language.
- (c) being able to learn mathematics or music in a foreign language.
- (d) expanding the mind to acquire new knowledge and skills.
- (e) none of the above.

3. **Which of the following statements is not made in the passage?**

- (a) All students should study a language in the University.
- (b) Foreign language learning enables one to appreciate other people's culture.
- (c) Teachers emphasise ability to communicate as a reward of foreign language learning.
- (d) Foreign language learning helps the study of other subjects.
- (e) Foreign language learners are usually better students than others.

4. **Discipline as used in the above passage means**

- (a) punishment.
- (b) lecturer.
- (c) skill.
- (d) training.
- (e) subject.

PASSAGE B

B. The earthly paradises of Bali and of the South Sea Islands, and non-acquisitive civilization of Burma, have been aptly described and romanticized. One can add to them the Nicobar Islands, where a small population lives happily on a very low cultural level. But perhaps, the most remarkable and the least known of these earthly paradises is the small kingdom of Huza in the Himalayas, which was recently visited and enthusiastically described by the journalist, Noel Barber (*Daily Mail*, 5, 6, 8 June 1962).

A fair-skinned population of 18,000, they live in a fertile and almost inaccessible valley not far from the Sinkiang border, 8,000 feet up. A legend has it that they are the descendants of three deserters from the army of Alexander the Great, who settled here with Persian wives which makes one inclined to believe that pacifism may be hereditary, because these people had no war in 2,000 years. They have no money, no crime, and no disease, they rarely die before ninety. Their psychosomatic control is almost unbelievable, childbirth is painless, and toothache, a joke; they keep their numbers stationary without contraceptives, and without abortion, but by sheer abstinence, though Noel Barber saw the newborn son of a chuckling father aged eighty nine. Their diet, which consists mostly of apricots and raw vegetables, may have something to do with their unshakable serenity. It makes one gasp with surprise that human nature can be like this. One is reminded of Huxley's Island, but unlike the Palanese, the Hunza people have no art, only serenity!

Fill in the following:

What is/the

- (a) **theme**
- (b) **subject matter?**
- (c) **difficult words?**
- (d) **difficult words?**
- (e) **difficult Idioms?**
- (f) **difficult phrasal verbs?**

- (g) difficult proverbs?
(h) types of questioning method used?

It is said in the passage that Noel Barber has

1.
(a) visited all the earthly paradises.
(b) visited only the Nicobar Islands.
(c) visited Hunza in the Himalayas.
(d) visited Hunza in the Himalays on 5, 6 and 8 June, 1962.
(e) not done any of the above.

The civilization of Burma and Nicobar Islands are

2.
(a) alike because both are romanticised.
(b) alike because both operate at low cultural levels.
(c) alike because one is gentle and non acquisitive and the other operates at a low cultural level.
(d) not alike because Burma has been described but the Nicobar Islands have not.
(e) not alike because the Nicobar Islands have a small population and Burma has a large population.

3. The kingdom of Hunza had no war in 2.000 years. This

- (a) proves that pacifism is hereditary.
(b) suggests that pacifism may be hereditary.
(c) shows that Alexander the Great was their ancestor, and he hated wars.
(d) is because they deserted the army of Alexander the Great.
(e) is because they could not fight.

4. Why is toothache a joke in Hunza?

- (a) It provides so much fun for the people.
(b) They joke to relieve its pain.
(c) Because they have no cure for it, it is better to joke about it.
(d) Civilized people must joke when they have toothache.
(e) Toothache is unknown.

5. To say that the Hunza people have serenity means they are

- (a) cultured. (b) contented. (c) artistic.
(d) friendly. (e) romantic.

6. Which of the following statements is not true of the Hunza people?

- (a) They have no money.
(b) There are no crimes.
(c) They have had no wars.
(d) They live till a ripe old age.
(e) They have no diseases.

PASSAGE V

The great herald of things to come was Ezekiel, not only in the sense that he predicted the future, but also because, in the manner and content of his prophetic ministry, he foreshadowed many of the important religious developments which were characteristic of the age after the Exile. He, rather than Ezra, was the founder of Judaism. He not only pointed forward; but as we shall see, he represented some of the great elements in Israel's religious past chronological arrangement of its contents. It purports to present the record of prophecies uttered in the Babylonian Exile between 593 and 571 BC; and for long this was not seriously questioned. Even when other prophetic books had been dissected and assigned to sundry authors and editors, this book continued to be regarded by most scholars as having come in its entirety from Ezekiel. Then came a period in which many extreme theories were advanced, assigning much later than the Babylonian Exile, or maintaining that Ezekiel's ministry was not exercised in Babylon but in Palestine, or at least was begun there. Such theories have been subjected to damaging criticism, and are now somewhat discredited. The account of Ezekiel's ministry and teaching is based on the view that he lived

and worked among the Exiles in Babylonia, at the period indicated, and that the bulk of the material in the book comes from him, though like other prophetic collection, it owes much in its compilation, arrangement, and transmission to prophetic disciples.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) **theme?**
- (b) **subject matter?**
- (c) **difficult words?**
- (d) **difficult words?**
- (e) **difficult Idioms?**
- (f) **difficult phrasal verbs?**
- (g) **difficult proverbs?**
- (h) **types of questioning method used?**

1. **Ezekiel was a great herald of things to come.**

- (a) He was a prophet.
- (b) He preached about events which were to characterize the period after the exile.
- (c) God showed him what going to happen after the exile.
- (d) He ran a prophetic ministry.
- (e) God was with him.

2. **In his work, Ezekiel**

- (a) was friendly with Ezra.
- (b) founded Judaism in conjunction with Ezra.
- (c) had a large religious following.
- (d) forged a link between the past and the future.
- (e) demonstrated that he was a man of God.

3. **By and large critics of Ezekiel and his work were**

- (a) successful.
- (b) ungodly.
- (c) unsuccessful.

- (d) jealous.
- (e) angered by his acceptance.

4. **When other prophetic books were discredited, Ezekiel's books were accepted because**

- (a) the people loved him.
- (b) the other prophetic writers were not as original.
- (c) the critics were biased in their judgement.
- (d) he was a great prophet.
- (e) his work was convincingly documented.

5. **The account of Ezekiel's ministry was**

- (a) compiled with the collaboration of others.
- (b) his and his alone.
- (c) shared by many writers.
- (d) partly composed by him and partly by Ezra.
- (e) produced as a result of God's inspiration.

PASSAGE VI

Over the years, there has been this hue and cry by governments and public policy advisers against the phenomenon of the rural-urban drift. Researches have been conducted on various aspects of this phenomenon which have resulted in the identification of the various causes and consequences of it. In addition, prescriptions have been given for controlling the rural-urban drift.

Among the causes most often mentioned are population pressures in some rural areas resulting in dwindling farm lands; increasing school enrolments and the resultant rise in educational levels which qualify many people for urban employment; higher wages in the urban centers relative to rural centers and the rather naïve one of the 'bright lights' in the cities so much touted by early foreign sociologists.

The most often mentioned consequences of this rural-urban migration include depopulation of the rural areas leading to overcrowding of the cities and the resultant housing and sanitation

problems; decline in the agricultural population resulting in less food crops being grown and high food prices in the cities, and increasing urban unemployment. The results of the phenomenon are seen largely as negative.

Measures to control the rural urban drift include the establishment of essential amenities like water, electricity, hospitals, colleges and cinema houses, the location of employment-generating establishments and the building of good interconnecting roads.

The sum total of these prescriptions in essence, unwittingly or paradoxically, is for the rural areas to be transformed into urban centres. This is so because to industrialize, the rural areas would draw many more people out of agriculture than if industries were restricted to urban centres.

When industries are located in the rural areas, it involves much less cost for the prospective rural-urban migrant to change to a non-agricultural job, than is involved in his leaving a rural abode for a distant urban centre.

Therefore, rural industrialization holds a higher potential for the de-agriculturalisation of the rural population than when industries are concentrated in urban areas.

The phenomenon of rural-urban migration has been intensively and extensively researched and studied; but it would seem that it has largely been misinterpreted and misunderstood. Consequently, public policies on the subject have largely been mis-directed.

Fill in the following:

What is/are the

- (a) **theme?**
- (b) **subject matter?**
- (c) **difficult words?**
- (d) **difficult words?**
- (e) **difficult idioms?**
- (f) **difficult phrasal verbs?**
- (g) **difficult proverbs?**

(h) types of questioning method used?

1. **The author explains that researches conducted on various aspects of rural-urban drift have**
 - (a) failed to provide effective solutions.
 - (b) revealed the causes and effects of this drift.
 - (c) increased the hue and cry against it.
 - (d) provided effective solutions to the problem.
 - (e) not only provided solutions but also brought the causes and effects of this drift
2. **One of the reasons why people drift from the rural areas to the urban areas is**
 - (a) hunger resulting from drought.
 - (b) laziness and ignorance.
 - (c) better rural education and possession of qualifications which make better jobs available in urban areas.
 - (d) the easy life and the comfort in the city.
 - (e) the freedom from traditional control and pagan practices.
3. **Migration in large numbers is said to result in**
 - (a) juvenile delinquency.
 - (b) a fall in the production of food, accommodation and health in cities.
 - (c) high way robbery.
 - (d) difficulty of life in rural areas.
 - (e) Mental stress by parents and relations.
4. **One suggested solution to the problem is to**
 - (a) provide social amenities and create employment opportunities in rural areas.
 - (b) encourage mechanized agriculture in order to raise income.
 - (c) force the young rural people to stay by warning them about the problem in cities.
 - (d) mount road blocks.

5. The consequences of the rural-urban drift are seen in the above passage as being
- (a) useful to the cities and not to the rural areas.
 - (b) a national disaster.
 - (c) a natural occurrence and sign of progress.
 - (d) negative.
 - (e) a healthy economic phenomenon.

PASSAGE VII

Rufus Okeke – Roof, for short – was a very popular man in his village. Although the villagers did not explain it in so many words, Roof's popularity was a measure of their gratitude to an energetic young man who unlike most of his fellows nowadays, had not abandoned the village in order to seek work, any work, in the towns, Roof was not a village tout either. Everyone knew how he has spent two years as a bicycle repairer's apprentice in Port-Harcourt and had given up of his own free will a bright future to return to his people and guide them in these political items.

Not that Umuofia needed a lot of guidance. The villagers already belonged en masse to the People's Alliance Party, and its most illustrious son, Chief the Honourable Marcus Ibe, was Minister of Culture in the outgoing government (which was pretty certain to be the incoming one as well). Nobody doubted that the Honourable Marcus Ibe was Minister of Culture in the outgoing government (which was pretty certain to be the incoming one as well). Nobody doubted that the Honourable Minister would be elected in his constituency. Opposition to him was like the proverbial fly trying to move a dunghill. It would have been ridiculous enough without coming, as it did now, from a complete nonentity.

As was to be expected, Roof was in the service of the Honourable Minister for the coming elections. He had become a real expert in election campaigning at all levels – village, local government or national. He could tell the mood and temper of the

electorate at any given time. For instance, he had warned the Minister months ago about the radical change that had come into the thinking of Umuofia since the last national election.

1. **Rufus Okeke was very popular with people because he**

- (a) was energetic.
- (b) had decided to pitch his tent with the village.
- (c) did not like town life.
- (d) could not live without his parents.
- (e) made more money for the villagers.

2. **A village tout can be described as being**

- (a) unemployed.
- (b) crazy.
- (c) energetic.
- (d) lazy.
- (e) servile.

3. **The reference to Okeke's *bright future* in Port-Harcourt can be described as being**

- (a) sarcastic.
- (b) true.
- (c) untrue.
- (d) irrelevant.
- (e) impossible.

4. **The writer is saying indirectly that political parties in power could be**

- (a) unpredictable.
- (b) honest.
- (c) corrupt.
- (d) servile.
- (e) autocratic.

5. **Which of the following statements would you consider correct with reference to Okeke as an election expert?**

- (a) It is true that he was an expert.
- (b) It is doubtful that he was an expert.
- (c) It is most likely to be true that he was an en expert.
- (d) There are no election experts.
- (e) He was not an election expert at all.

TOP SECRETS REVEALED

WHAT YOU SHOULD KNOW ABOUT THE UME/PCE THAT YOU ARE GOING TO SIT FOR.

The Examination itself

The UME Use of English is divided into four major parts:

Comprehension, Collocation, Lexis and Structure and Oral Forms. There are usually three passages under comprehension, each with five questions carrying 3 marks each. Next is Collocation - 10 questions with 2 marks each, and the third aspect is the Lexis and Structure - 75 questions of 1 mark each all totalling 140 marks. A separate section has been devoted to Oral English. You understand quite well what comprehension is. But, what is Collocation?

Collocation

This is usually the question part that follows the comprehension i.e. questions 16 - 25. Collocation refers to the grouping of words together with special note on the company that words keep. Certain combination of words cannot be changed, e.g. **hook, line and sinker; lock, stock and barrel; live a dog's life**. These words are essentially meant to be together to bring out the meaning of each of the expressions mentioned above.

Nothing can therefore change **live a dog's life** to, **live a goat's life**. So, you should understand that there are certain words that should always go with each other in order to realise the real meaning of the expression.

Now, pick the UME 1992 English question paper and study questions 16-25. We have mentioned that the essential characteristic of collocation is that, certain words keep company with one another.

Look at these:

A book can be **ENLARGED**

The price (of goods) can be **INCREASED**

A **discussion** can be **PROLONGED**

Profit can be **MAXIMISED**

A **bridge** can be **WIDENED**, etc.

But we cannot **ENLARGE** a discussion or profit nor can we **MAXIMISE** a bridge or book.

How do you approach that part of the examination, i.e. collocation?

Since it is usually in comprehension –passage form, you should quickly glance through the passage to determine the **REGISTER** of the discussion.

What is **REGISTER**?

This is the set of words, **registered** trade-marks of certain aspects of human endeavour. Almost every aspect of endeavour has its register, i.e. the special words that are used in discussing that endeavour. For example, the legal register has **court, lawyer, plaintiff, registrar, judge, dock, adjournment, service, five trial, defendant** etc.

So, you have to skim through the Collocation passage first to get a "gist" of what aspect of human endeavour is being discussed – is it sports, religion, language, commerce, science, building etc? It is after this that you can decide which words are to be used.

LEXIS AND STRUCTURE

What is Lexis? What is structure? How many questions on each should you expect in the examination? What is the general approach?

LEXIS means words. Each word in English, Russian, Yoruba, Hausa or French is an example of **LEXIS** or we can call each a **LEXICAL ITEM**. So, the meaning of individual words is tested when **LEXIS** questions are set.

STRUCTURE refers to the combination of each of these words to form correct sentences. This part, has to do with the rules governing the formation of certain sentences, which include topics such as question tags, determiners, apostrophe, concord etc.

Question Distribution for **LEXIS** and **STRUCTURE**

Of the 75 questions allotted **Lexis** and **Structure**, 30 may be from lexis, 30 from structure and fifteen from oral English. This ensures that all aspects are adequately touched by the questions.

TIME STRATEGY

JAMB examiners know that if candidates are allowed sufficient time to face the examination, they (candidates) may manage to score 100 percent.

As a result of this, the time allowed for your 'Use of English' paper, especially – and indeed, all other papers, is very little. That is their strategy and coup of time against you. Or, what can an average candidate do within 75 minutes on 3 comprehension passages, 10 collocation and 75 lexis and structure questions?. So, I advise you have your own time-attack strategy.

First, have a dependable wristwatch. Secondly, start answering the questions from the comprehension part – Remember you are NOT to read the passage first but **read all the five questions first**. Try, not to forget all the questions you have been asked under the passage. Then, go on to read the passage. You may have to underline certain parts of the passage that seem to be your answer.

You have learnt, also, that you should not guess your answer. The principle is this: if you do not know the answer to any question,

leave it and return to it later. I have discussed how you will handle a situation where you have identical answers and how you will know the correct answer.

Still under time strategy, make sure you allocate a specific number of minutes to comprehension and other aspects. Make sure you do not spend more time than you have allocated. Do not worry if you do not finish your work. Do your best to answer correctly as many questions as possible under comprehension, as it offers a good opportunity to score the highest mark.

HOW YOUR PAPER IS MARKED

As you may well have known, all your papers are computer – marked. The computer answer sheet you submit will not be fed into the computer until it has been checked and found well shaded. If a candidate shades just few answers, it is the practice not to feed such into the computer.

Thousands of candidates sit for the University Matriculation Examination (UME) every year. However, just a small percentage end up getting the much desired admission into universities. This book, *A-Z of JAMB's Use of English*, sets out to reduce the rate of failure and thus put Nigerian students on the right track.

The book is divided into three sections. Section 1 treats the intricacies of grammar, and highlights the reasons for students' failure in UME; Section 2 examines aspects of Oral English; while Section 3 amplifies various ways of answering comprehension passages without stress.

A-Z of JAMB's Use of English is practice-oriented, easy to understand and a sure way of gaining admission into Nigerian universities. It is equally good for those who want to improve on their use of the English language.



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